Dell Technologies Unified Style Guide

Version 1.0

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Introduction to the Dell Technologies Unified Style Guide

What is it and who does it serve? The *Dell Technologies Unified Style Guide* (USG) is a set of style standards for content creators who work across Dell and across the full range of Dell's product lines. Whether you create technical content or you write or design for the UI, the USG is your style guide. This guide replaces:

- Technical Writers Style Guide
- APEX Style Guide
- Content guidance contained with the Dell Digital Design System 2.0
- Content guidance contained within the Experience Design Group (EDG) ISG Design System 1.0

What prompted this collaboration? At the release of USG v1.0, teams from four organizations had committed to this unification effort: Content Engineering and Translation (formerly IDD, now CE&T), Dell Digital (DD), Experience Design Group (EDG), and Dell Brand. These groups began their partnership with their work on the APEX line of business. The complex interdependencies between APEX offers and other Dell products across the portfolio pushed us to create a unified content style guide. We all needed to be on the same page. This guide supports Dell's corporate pillars: simple, modern, and *consistent*.

How can different types of content use the same guidelines? We recognize that our content serves different purposes—some helps customers use our products, while others persuade or inform. However, the teams that manage and use the USG are dedicated to following a unified set of practices and standards across all types of content. We also acknowledge that we may be using a different voice or tone depending on content function (see Voice and tone). The Dell Technologies Glossary, also called Acrolinx, records differences in terminology.

What does it cover? The USG is intended to be the first point of reference for both technical writers and those UX/UI designers and writers engaged in developing UI design and workflow. The USG focuses solely on *content* and doesn't provide direction on visual or design construction. Content guidance provided by the USG for a component within a design library overrides any conflicting guidance in the design system library. It's the design system owner's responsibility to stay consistent with the USG.

Other resources: For information that is not covered in either this style guide or in the Dell Technologies Glossary, see the latest editions of the following resources, in the following order or precedence:

The Chicago Manual of Style

Microsoft Writing Style Guide

The IBM Style Guide

Merriam-Webster's Collegiate Dictionary

How to get involved: Submit any questions or suggested changes to [TBD]. The USG team is responsible for, updating, and maintaining the *Unified Style Guide*. If you or your organization are interested in collaborating with the USG team, contact [TBD].

NOTE: You'll find that many topics end with a change log. These logs will be deprecated in the next version.

NOTE: *[TBD]* indicates missing information and, in a few cases, a missing topic.

Voice and tone

Follow these guidelines for voice and tone.

NOTE: For active and passive voice, see Active and passive voice.

Related topics

Conversational tone compared with formal tone

In general, Dell style uses a *conversational* tone to communicate with its CSG Client customers and a *formal* tone to communicate with its ISG Enterprise customers.

At Dell, conversational and formal writing styles follow the same guidelines. So, this topic presents overall concepts of voice and tone and general writing guidelines. The USG mentions differences between conversational and formal writing styles only where they diverge.

Specific ISG products and components that use a conversational tone include the UI for APEX.

Voice

Voice conveys personality. Dell Technologies is committed to **maintaining a consistent voice** that delivers technology solutions to drive human progress. Four brand principles represent the Dell Technologies voice.

We are collaborative: We are positive and action oriented. We resolve conflict by asking unbiased questions and encouraging resolution. We lead with mutual trust and respect. We are open to change. We consider every viable voice, experience, and result before acting. We are intentional and sensitive, and we strive to open new conversations at every opportunity.

We are authentic: We speak plainly and remove unnecessary jargon. We use inclusive language that respects all individuals, cultures, and communities. We prioritize gender-neutral phrases and terms. We are honest about what we do. We consider accessibility in everything we create. We write for multiple use cases.

We are reliable: We connect ideas to actions and results, and then back up those claims with examples. Our language only makes promises that our products can keep. We write for current functionality, not future updates. We are realistic about our goals and make small changes along the way.

We are bold: We are here to support and empower people and organizations to move forward. We do that by reflecting on feedback, responding in a timely manner, and anticipating user needs in new, innovative ways. This often requires us to change our understanding of the world, and we do that graciously.

The following voice-scale tables are a way of thinking about the process of building a strong personality by positioning the Dell Technologies brand between opposing, off-brand characteristics. In the case of

formal writing, Dell Technologies uses a stronger collaborative voice with three characteristics and a stronger authentic voice with one characteristic.

Table 1. Collaborative voice-scale characteristics

(Stronger)	**Collaborative**	**(Weaker)**
Select[2]	Inclusive[1]	Loose
Prescriptive[2]	Helpful[1]	Easy
Authoritative	Encouraging[1 2]	Inspiring
Academic[2]	Transparent[1]	Frank

[1] Conversational Dell Technologies voice.
[2] Formal Dell Technologies voice.

Table 2. Authentic voice-scale characteristics

(Stronger)	**Authentic**	**(Weaker)**
Conservative	Honest[1 2]	Showy
Technical[2]	Approachable[1]	Colloquial
Equivocal	Straightforward[1 2]	Blunt
Formulaic	Human[1 2]	Errant

[1] Conversational Dell Technologies voice.
[2] Formal Dell Technologies voice.

Table 3. Reliable voice-scale characteristics

(Stronger)	**Reliable**	**(Weaker)**
Zealous	Committed[1 2]	Fancy-free
Somber	Serious[1 2]	Glib
Nebulous	Clear[1 2]	Curt
Weighty	Substantial[1 2]	Fantastic

[1] Conversational Dell Technologies voice.
[2] Formal Dell Technologies voice.

Table 4. Bold voice-scale characteristics

(Stronger)	Bold	(Weaker)
Traditional	Modern[1] [2]	Groundbreaking
Arrogant	Confident[1] [2]	Unpredictable
Sure	Optimistic[1] [2]	Revolutionary
Diffuse	Focused[1] [2]	Single-minded

[1] Conversational Dell Technologies voice.
[2] Formal Dell Technologies voice.

Tone

While voice remains an overall constant, tone is relative to an individual task, the person being spoken to, or the action being accomplished. It is the emotional delivery or attitude present when conveying messaging based on voice. The Dell Technologies tone is friendly, calm, candid, conversational, neutral, and respectful in most cases. However, these characteristics can change to match the context of a particular communication.

When writing to someone, ask yourself the following questions:

- Why am I writing this?
- Who is reading this?
- What do I want the reader to learn, understand, and think about?

The type, urgency, and frequency of content also gives an indication of how and why tone should change.

On a scale between both concise and detailed and conversational and serious, consider the following types of common messages and the tonal characteristics that would apply.

- Task completion and form instructions: concise and conversational.
- Notifications, getting started guides, and billing and payment: neutral tone.
- Confirmations: concise.
- Errors: concise and serious.
- Onboarding documentation: detailed and conversational.
- Support documentation: detailed.
- Disclaimers: detailed and serious.

The following diagram provides a visual representation of these types of common messages and the applicable tonal characteristics.

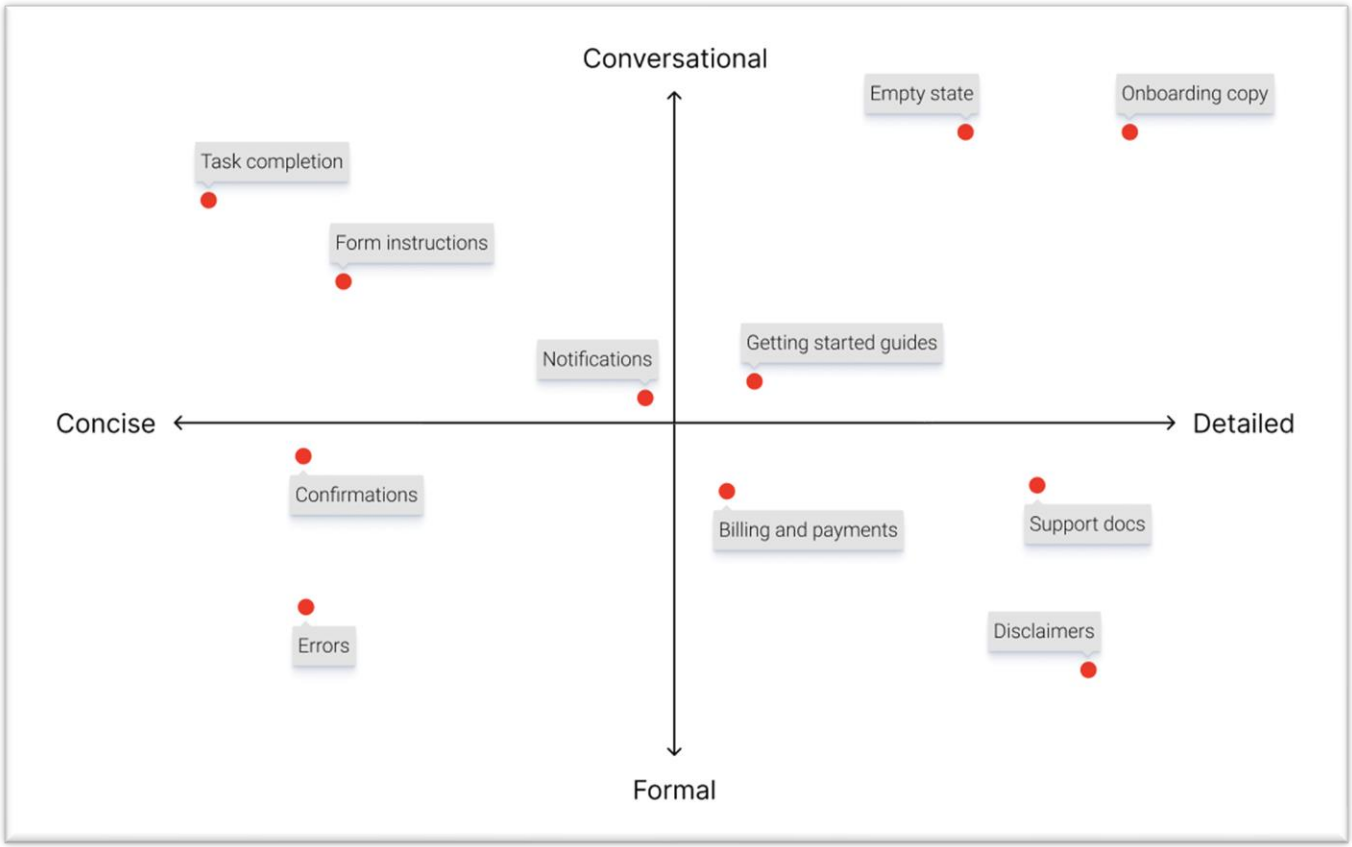


Figure 1. Common message types and applicable tonal qualities

The following examples provide more detailed scenarios of types of content and the kind of tone to use.

Example 1

Your workstream project manager has let you know that your offer is getting a new brochure for release at an upcoming conference. Marketing owns the brochure, but they want to collaborate because you wrote the offer description in the console.

- You are writing this to explain Dell Technologies to anyone who attends the conference.
- You are communicating with an executive member, a business-development analyst, or a business consultant.
- You want the reader to learn about the offer's availability, to understand what capabilities Dell Technologies has, and to think about buying a new service.

Your tone for this task is conversational, detailed, persuasive, informative, respectful, and encouraging.

Example 2

Your sales team has given feedback that it is time-consuming to make necessary edits to their client billing information because the console functionality is difficult to find. You are unable to change the product, but you can suggest an email workflow that sends a shortcut to the sales representative every time a customer requests a billing update.

- You are writing this to decrease the time spent completing a necessary billing change.
- You are communicating with the internal Dell Technologies sales team.
- You want the reader to learn a new process for editing customer billing information, to understand how to make a change with minimal effort, and to decrease the time they spend thinking about billing changes.

Your tone for this task is detailed, familiar, concise, helpful, empathetic, and accommodating.

Example 3

You are coding new functionality to give IT specialists the ability to set custom thresholds to flag an account when critical usage numbers are reached. This feature has been requested by the users, so it is important that it meets usability expectations.

- You are coding this to give customizable functionality to the users.
- You are communicating with account administrators and IT specialists.
- You want the users to learn how to make comprehensive but specific custom thresholds for automatic notification, to understand the information they need to use the new functionality, and to think that this new feature fits within their expectations and workflow needs.

Your tone for this task is thorough, direct, actionable, familiar, detailed, and practical.

Personas

Personas are archetypical readers or users whose goals and characteristics represent the needs of a larger target audience. Personas help writers and software designers understand and empathize with the target audience of a piece of writing or user-centered design. When writing or designing for a particular audience using a persona, continually ask questions from their perspective.

For more information about personas, see Personas.

Writing-style guidelines for voice and tone

- Keep content clear and easy to read. Remember that when someone is using a screen reader, the content is spoken aloud, so it should also be easy to listen to.
- Avoid formal words in conversational writing. However, remember that serious is different from formal.
- Present only the information that readers need, and only when they need it.

- Keep sentences simple. In conversational writing, aim for readability between fifth and eighth grades. You can use Acrolinx to check the reading level of your content. If referring to the Flesch Reading Ease scale, aim for a score between 100 and 65.
- Keep the word count to 25 or under per sentence. In some cases, formal writing can require more words than conversational writing.
- Do not use more than 5 sentences in a paragraph.
- Use active voice except when you want to emphasize the action over the subject for easier scanning or the subject is irrelevant or obvious.
- Write in the present tense.
- Write in the indicative and imperative moods.
- Make titles and headings unique and informative.
- Use headings, subheadings, and bullet points to make content easy to scan.
- Begin action sentences with the objective. For example, use a format like to do x, do y. This makes it easier to parse because if you don't care about x, you don't need to read the rest of the sentence.
- Keep interface terms such as menu, tabs, and pane consistent, either throughout product screens or in descriptive topics.
- In conversational writing used in a user-interface element or for non-technical content, use contractions.

  Incorrect: We cannot process your request at this time.
  Correct: We can't process your request right now.
- In formal writing or conversational writing used for technical content, do not use contractions.

  Incorrect: We can't process your request right now.
  Correct: Your request cannot be processed.
- In conversational writing, apologize only in error messages when the issue is clearly the fault of Dell Technologies. The same applies for using *please*—use it only when asking users to perform an unexpected or irregular action.

  Incorrect: An error prevented this update. Try again later.
  Correct: Sorry, an error prevented this update. Please try again later.
- In formal writing, do not apologize or use *please*.

  Incorrect: Sorry, you can't save a draft without filling out all the required fields. Review your form and try again.
  Correct: Enter a valid email address to save your draft.
- Write as you would speak.

  Incorrect: Would you like to exit the console without saving your current changes?
  Correct: Exit without saving?

- Be friendly, but not funny.

  Incorrect: Oops! Looks like something went completely wrong. But don't worry, it can happen to anyone, and it just happened to you. We'll get it fixed as soon as possible! In the meantime, why don't you do something else?
  Correct: This page isn't available. Try searching for something else.

- Make the content scannable. The biggest part of being plainspoken and clear is being concise. Make the language as simple as it can be without over-simplifying. Be specific.

  Incorrect: Save this credit card as my preferred payment method for associated purchases.
  Correct: Make this credit card my default payment method.

- Use personal language. Use the second person point of view and imperative sentences to create agency. Use *you* to humanize the language and speak directly to the reader whenever appropriate, such as in alerts, notifications, and confirmation messages. Formal writing uses the second person less often, but it is still used when the alternative is either less direct or more difficult to parse.

  Incorrect: There is an unread notification from Dell Technologies regarding billing address updates.
  Correct: You have a new message about billing address updates.

- Use familiar and simple terms whenever possible. It saves readers time and grows their confidence in our products when what they read feels familiar to them, even if it is their first time reading it. Defer to plain language, well-known terms, and proven best practices for common interactions.

  Incorrect: The time-to-value for this service is as little as 14 days.
  Correct: You can deploy this service in as few as 14 days.

- Be straightforward. Using bold language requires good planning. Consider the timing, tone, phrasing, and desired outcome. Always pay attention to conversations or topics that might be sensitive and work to understand them. Outline next steps if resolution requires additional focus. Be hopeful, open, and solution oriented.

  Although the same guideline applies to both conversational and formal writing, the syntax used with each can be reversed.

  Incorrect (conversational): Invalid password. Try again.
  Correct (conversational): That password isn't right. Recover it?

  Incorrect (formal): That password isn't right. Recover it?
  Correct (formal): Invalid password. Try again.

- Reduce bias. Choose words that are appropriately specific and only describe relevant characteristics. Be sensitive to group labels and don't use them unless explicitly necessary. Describe groups instead of using broad categories. Use terms to indicate the context of the action or participation of the user, rather than the user themself.

  Incorrect: The over-25 group of people in the study responded well to the interface.
  Correct: The study participants in the 25 to 35 age group responded well to the interface.

- Be consistent. Use the same tense, same voice, and same tone for similar messages. Defer to the established language if the language appears elsewhere, or change the established language at the same time you release the new language elsewhere.

  Incorrect (different instances): Your draft has been updated. | Your draft has been saved. | Changes have been saved to [draft name]. | Your changes were successfully saved. | Your draft is updated.
  Correct (every instance): Your changes are saved.

Related topics

Active and passive voice

Contractions

Sentences

Change notes

Existing guideline	New guideline	Affected groups
The maximum word count guideline varies between the different groups.	Keep the word count to 25 or under per sentence.	All
N/A	Do not use more than 5 sentences in a paragraph.	All

Grammar and style

The topics in this section address how to use the different parts of speech and how to use the active voice.

Abbreviations

Abbreviations include acronyms, initialisms, and truncated words. An abbreviation is a shortened form of a word (amt in place of amount). An acronym is made up of parts of the phrase it stands for and is pronounced as a word (NATO, AIDS, EULA). An initialism is an acronym that is pronounced as individual letters (CPU, SSD, DNA). A truncated word is a commonly used syllable or piece of a longer word that has come to represent the same meaning (auto in place of automobile).

Follow these guidelines for using abbreviations:

- Always use complete, Brand-approved names of Dell products. Never abbreviate them. Never use internal product or offer code names or abbreviations.

  Incorrect: APEX Navigator elevates your cloud experience.

  Incorrect: Cirrus elevates your cloud experience.

  Correct: Dell APEX Navigator for Multicloud Storage elevates your cloud experience.

- When using abbreviations that are not familiar to your target audience, spell them out in the first instance per topic, page, or component. Include the abbreviated form in parentheses immediately after the spelled-out form. For all subsequent instances within that topic, page, or component, use the abbreviated form of the term.

  Incorrect: Configuration of virtual machines (VMs)

  Correct: Configuration of virtual machines

- When a term first appears in a title and requires an abbreviation, use only the spelled-out form in the title. Then, on its first occurrence within the topic, use the spelled-out form followed by the abbreviation. If the spelled-out form is too lengthy for a title, use only the abbreviation. Provide the spelled-out form followed by the abbreviation in parentheses upon its first occurrence in the topic..

- Do not spell out abbreviations whose meanings are common knowledge and more easily recognizable than their spelled-out forms, for example, XML and HTML. Where there is a question of whether the abbreviation of a term is common knowledge, present the abbreviation first, then spell it out within parentheses immediately following. Submit the term and abbreviation for common knowledge assessment to the terminology workgroup.

- Do not use Latin abbreviations. See Latin abbreviations.

- Do not spell out an abbreviation that is part of a proper noun (for example, EISA Configuration Utility) even if it is the only occurrence in the topic.

- Except with units of measure and other exceptions noted in the Dell Technologies Glossary, add a lowercase *s* to write the plural form of an abbreviation. Do not add an apostrophe or an uppercase *S*.

  Incorrect: LAN's.

  Correct: LANs.

- Do not use an apostrophe *s* at the end of an abbreviation to create a possessive, for example, *the OEM's software product*. Instead, use the abbreviation as a modifier.

  Incorrect: Use the NVBU's command line utility to perform these actions.

  Correct: Use the NVBU command line utility to perform these actions.

- When using an abbreviation, do not repeat the word that the last letter in the abbreviation stands for.

  Incorrect: HTTP protocol

  Correct: HTTP

- To determine whether to precede an abbreviation with *a* or *an*, pronounce the abbreviation and use the appropriate article according to the sound (not the spelling) of the abbreviation. Use *a* with abbreviations that begin with a consonant sound and use *an* with abbreviations that begin with a vowel sound.

  Incorrect: an serial cable, a SEO strategy

  Correct: *a* serial cable, *an* SEO strategy

- Abbreviate measurements, except for the units of measure noted in the Dell Technologies Glossary. For more information about abbreviations for measurements, see Units of measurement.

- Use a period with abbreviations only if they would be confused with other common words.

  Incorrect: 5.25 in

  Correct: 5.25 in.

- Do not use abbreviations as verbs. For example, use *transfer a file using FTP* instead of *FTP a file*.

- When attaching a prefix to an abbreviation, use a hyphen.

- When spelling out abbreviations, use the correct capitalization. Not all abbreviations take initial uppercase letters. For information about writing abbreviations, including correct spelling and capitalization, see Capitalization and the Dell Technologies Glossary.

- When writing about a file type in text, use the file extension in capital letters without a period. When referring to a specific filename, use the extension in lower case with a period.

  Incorrect: Copy the .html files into the directory. Go to the folder in which you saved setup.EXE.

  Correct: Copy the HTML files into the directory. Go to the folder in which you saved setup.exe.

Change notes

No substantive changes made.

Sources:

- **APEX SG**
- **TWSG**

Active and passive voice

For voice and tone as personality, see Voice and tone.

- Prefer active voice over passive voice. Use active voice because it is more straightforward, less wordy, and easier to read, understand, and translate than passive voice.

  In the following, all Incorrect examples are in the passive voice and all Correct examples are in the active voice.

  Incorrect: Active voice is recommended.

  Correct: Use the active voice.

  Incorrect: It is recommended to avoid passive voice.

  Correct: Avoid passive voice where possible.

  Incorrect: The operating system for the server must be selected.

  Correct: Select the operating system for the server.

  Incorrect: A backup was performed [by System X].

  Correct: System X is backing up the data.

  Incorrect: Changes to the procedure must be recorded in the primary file.

  Correct: If you change the procedure, record the change in the primary file.

  Incorrect: The system is restarted when you submit the request.

  Correct: The system restarts when you submit the request.

  Correct: To restart the system, submit the request.

  Correct: Submit the request to restart the system.

  Correct: Submitting the request restarts the system.
- Passive voice is sometimes necessary and sometimes intentional. It's used deliberately to shift the focus of the sentence onto the action or the object receiving the action.
- Top of Form
- The one specific case where Dell technical writers are asked to use passive voice is to recommend a certain action or behavior on behalf of the company.

Incorrect: Dell recommends that you remove the hard drive before removing the fan.

Correct: It is recommended that you remove the hard drive before removing the fan.

Identifying active and passive voices

If you struggle to identify subjects and objects, pay attention to the noun that comes before the verb. Active voice starts with who or what is *doing* the action, while passive voice starts with who or what is *receiving* the action.

Active voice	Passive voice
Has a **subject—verb—object** word order. John (subject) opened (verb) the door. (object)	Uses an **Object—verb—subject** word order. The door (object) was opened (verb) by John. (subject)
Identifies the entity performing the action (subject) before the action (verb).	The entity receiving the verb's action (object) is identified before the action (verb).
Identifies the entity receiving the verb's action (object) after the verb.	The entity performing the action (subject) is named last or omitted. When identified, *by <who or what>* wording is used. When omitted or implied, the question ... *by <who or what>?* could logically be asked.
Tends to be more concise than passive sentences.	Uses the past participle form of the verb, preceded by a form of the verb "to be" (is, are, was, will be, have been, had been, will have been, can be), depending on tense.
Is easy to parse and understand on first reading.	A heavier cognitive load is placed on the reader since the action flows backwards (object ← is acted upon ← by subject).
Includes statements framed in the **imperative mood**. The entity performing the action [you] is implied before the verb: Click the button. Enter a value. Select an item.	

Change notes

No substantive changes made. Topic title changed from *Voice* to *Active and passive voice*.

Sources: TWSG, IDS, APEX SG

Addresses

Follow these guidelines when including addresses of physical locations in written content:

- Follow the formatting standards for addresses and locations as detailed in Locale format standards.
- Use the full and proper name when referring to an address as a noun. For example, use *I live at 601 Cedar Street* instead of *I live on Cedar Street*.
- You may use the abbreviated form when using an address as an adjective. For example, use *I work in an office that is located at 701 Maple Ave* instead of *I work in an office on Maple Avenue*.
- Do not use colloquial forms for a location, for example, use *United States* instead of *America*.
- Use commas to separate the elements of an address, but do not precede the zip code with a comma.

  Example: Dell Technologies is headquartered at *One Dell Way, Round Rock, Texas 78682*.

Search online to see whether locations commonly include *the* before their name, for example, *the Philippines* or *the Netherlands*.

NOTE: Flag to your engineering team information that requires globalization to avoid mishandling. Dates, phone numbers, addresses, names, and currency rely on APIs to internationalize by locale. For details, see Locale format standards.

Change notes

No substantive changes made.

Sources:

- APEX SG

Anthropomorphism

Anthropomorphism is the practice of attributing human characteristics to inanimate objects.

Follow these guidelines:

- Avoid Anthropomorphism. Focus on users and their actions and not on product functions or features.

  Incorrect: The control partition *decides to* switch roles.

Correct: The control partition *switches* roles.

Incorrect: If the system *sees* a new device, it changes the settings automatically.

Correct: If the system *detects* a new device, it changes the settings automatically.

- If you cannot avoid focusing on the product functions or features, use verbs that are appropriate for both people and things.

  Incorrect: The processor *thinks before informing* system board components to perform a task.

  Correct: The processor *communicates* with other system board components to perform a task.

  Incorrect: The computer's hard drive *remembers* data that is accessible even after the computer is restarted.

  Correct: The computer's hard drive *stores* data that is accessible even after the computer is restarted.

Articles

Articles indicate whether a noun is indefinite (*a, an*) or definite (*the*).

- Use the appropriate indefinite articles (*a, an*) and the definite article (*the*) where necessary.
- Whether to use *a* or *an* depends on the pronunciation of the noun that follows the article—the noun that the article modifies. If the noun that follows the article is pronounced with a consonant sound, use *a*. If the noun that follows the article is pronounced with a vowel sound, use *an*.

  Correct: ***a* feature, *a* field, *an* option, *an* icon, *a* useful tip, *a* URL, *a* user**
- Use the definite article, *the*, when you refer to specific nouns and when you refer to a noun that you have already introduced to the reader.

  Correct: **Click Close to exit *the* program.**
- In general, do not use articles with proper nouns. However, do use an article when you use a proper noun as an adjective.

  Incorrect: The OpenManage Network Manager provides configuration management automation.

  Correct: OpenManage Network Manager provides configuration management automation.

  Incorrect: OpenManage Network Manager software provides configuration management automation.

  Correct: The OpenManage Network Manager software provides configuration management automation.

  Incorrect: Dell Technologies PowerEdge C4130 rack server supports 16 DIMMs.

  Correct: The Dell Technologies PowerEdge C4130 rack server supports 16 DIMMs.

- Include appropriate definite or indefinite articles with abbreviations. For more information about using indefinite articles with abbreviations, see Abbreviations.

Change notes

No substantive changes made.

Sources:

- IDS
- APEX SG
- TWSG

Capitalization

Capitalization broadly impacts our content, both in documents and in UI design and microcopy. We typically speak of two capitalization schemas:

> *Title-case* capitalization refers to using initial uppercase letters for all words *except* prepositions containing three letters or less, articles, and conjunctions.
>
> *Sentence-case* capitalization refers to using initial uppercase letters only for the first word and proper noun in a title or header.

Follow these capitalization guidelines:

> **NOTE**: Guidance on tabs, column headings, and other UI components to come. Because our design groups use different component design systems with different capitalization patterns, we have tackled the larger elements first, and continue to work on the smaller elements.

- Use title-case capitalization in UI or web page navigation components, H1-level web page headings, button labels, and in document titles.

  NOTE: Illustrations of UI applications to come.

- Use sentence-case capitalization in UI or web page body text and text at the H2 and lower levels. For documentation, use sentence-case capitalization for chapter, topic, table, and figure titles.

- Only capitalize proper nouns, including brand, product, and service names, while following brand guidelines. Do not capitalize a term because you think it is important or that it needs emphasis. Be able to show that it is a proper noun.

  Incorrect: You can also manually search for and install *Driver Updates* for your computer at Dell Support > Drivers & Downloads.

  Correct: You can also manually search for and install *driver updates* for your computer at Dell Support > Drivers & Downloads.

- Do not use internal capitalization unless it is part of a brand name such as PowerEdge or SupportAssist.
- In document titles, use uppercase for the initial letter of proper nouns and proper noun phrases in compound phrases. However, if the first word of the compound is a prefix, make the second word lowercase unless it is a proper noun or proper adjective. Capitalize the prefix itself.

  Incorrect: Installing non-Dell Products

  Correct: Installing Non-Dell Technology Products
- Capitalize both words in a compound phrase such as *User-Defined* when it occurs at the beginning of a sentence. Also capitalize them when you are using a prefix within a proper noun phrase such as *APEX Customer-Managed Data Storage Service*, or when the compound phrase is located within text that takes title case.
- Use uppercase for the initial letter of the first word in a list unless the word always begins with a lowercase letter, such as iDRAC and iSCSI.
- Do not use all capital letters, except for stand-alone file extensions such as EXE and HTML, but [filename].html for full filenames with extensions.
- Do not use all capital letters to emphasize something.
- When a colon is used within a sentence, the first word following the colon is lowercased unless it is a proper noun. When a colon introduces two or more sentences or when it introduces speech in dialogue or a quotation or question, the first word following it is capitalized.

  Correct: The laptop is available in three skins: stainless steel, neon, or leather.

  Correct: Your choice of service contract length is critical: A one-year term may provide more flexibility. A three-year term, however, comes at a much lower rate.
- When referring to a document without using its complete title, use lowercase.

  Incorrect: For more information about replacing the heat sink, see *the Owner's Manual*.

  Correct: For more information about replacing the heat sink, see *the owner's manual*.
- When referring to a specific Dell Technologies document title, use title case and italics.

  Incorrect: For more information about replacing the heat sink, see *Dell PowerEdge Server R640 owner's manual*.

  Correct: For more information about replacing the heat sink, see *Dell PowerEdge Server R640 Owner's Manual*.
- When referring to third-party documentation, capitalize titles as they appear on the documents.
- Do not capitalize product descriptors such as switch, router, server, and so on.

  Correct: PowerEdge server, PowerVault switch
- Capitalize Dell organizational units, but not words like *team* or *department*.

  Correct: The Support *team* must respond within two days.

- Where you use a slash to present options in a table heading or in a UI component field label, capitalize items before and after the slash.

  Correct: State/Province

- For capitalization applied to specific UI design components, see the relevant UI Components topic. Guidance offered with individual components is not expected to conflict with what you find here, but if it does, contact the USG Governance Team.

Related topics

- About
- Accordion
- Action
- Anchored Nav
- App Launcher
- Badge
- Banners
- Blockquote
- Breadcrumbs
- Buttons
- Call to action (CTA)
- Carousels
- Cards
- Checkbox
- Contact Drawer
- Date and Time Picker
- Dashboard
- Detail Panel
- Dialogs
- Dividers and Containers
- Drawer
- Dropdown menus
- Dual List Box
- Empty State Messages
- Error messaging
- File input
- Filtering
- Fixed headers and navigation
- Footnote
- Get Started
- Global Alerts
- Grid

- Group titles
- Headings and body text
- Help
- Helper text
- Infinite Scroll
- Inline Alerts
- Instructional/Directional Messaging
- Intro
- Links
- Lists
- Loading indicator
- Login
- Menu text
- Message bar
- Modal windows
- Navigation
- Notifications
- Notifications, errors, and alert messages
- Off Canvas
- Overlay
- Pagination
- Pills
- Popover and tooltips
- Product Stack
- Progress bar
- Progress tracker
- Radio buttons
- Select Boxes
- Segmented Button
- Sidebar
- Side navigation
- Sliders
- Scrollbar
- Splash Screen
- Success messages
- Tables
- Tabs
- Tags
- Text area
- Text input

- Toggle Switches
- Tooltip
- Trigger labels
- Tree View
- View more/less
- What's New
- Wizard

Change notes

Sources:

- TWSG
- DD
- IDS

Existing guideline	New guideline	Affected guides
Capitalization of compound nouns separated by a hyphen did not address second term	Updated capitalization of compound nouns separated by a hyphen to say that *both terms* are capitalized	All
Not a guideline change but a practice change	Apply title case to button labels	APEX UI team (not the APX SG)
Not specified	Use sentence-case capitalization for chapter, topic, table, and figure titles.	TWSG Note that this isn't a change, but an elaboration on previous guidance. The chapter title capitalization rule was omitted from the TWSG.

Colloquialisms, idioms, and jargon

Follow these guidelines for using colloquialisms, idioms, and jargon:

- Colloquialisms, idioms, and jargon use regional, social, or technical descriptions for things that are understood by the groups that use them. However, these descriptions can be confusing or even objectionable to those not used to them. Where possible, use plain language instead.

- Do not use colloquialisms or idioms that might not be appropriate for most audiences. Colloquialisms and idioms can make your content confusing when translated to other languages.

  Incorrect: I had to restart my computer because it *crashed*.

  Correct: I had to restart my computer because it *stopped responding*.

  Incorrect: Keep network *down time* to a minimum.

  Correct: Keep network *outages* to a minimum.

  Incorrect: If you have questions about your network, consult with your *admin*.

  Correct: If you have questions about your network, consult with your *network administrator*.

- Avoid using jargon except industry-accepted jargon.

  Industry-accepted jargon is jargon that is common enough to have sufficient search volume or audience comprehension. It might be appropriate from an SEO perspective to use jargon. When undesirable terminology is necessary, it is best to instead add it to search elements that are less customer-facing, such as image alt text, if possible.

- If an ordinary term is as effective as jargon, use the ordinary term or rephrase the sentence.

  Incorrect: Our economy is in a *period of economic adjustment*.

  Correct: Our economy is in a *recession*.

  Incorrect: The computer displays a *Blue Screen of Death*.

  Correct: The computer displays a *critical error message*.

  Incorrect: Create a *rule for blocking unsolicited email messages*.

  Correct: *Create a spam filter.*

Contractions

The use or avoidance of contractions is one of the few differences between writing in the formal voice and writing in the conversational voice. See Voice and tone for a discussion on the differences and applications of these two voices.

Formal

Do not use contractions when writing technical documentation. Formal content includes most technical writing and EEMI standards usage.

- Do not use contractions because doing so could make it sound like imprecise wording is being used.

  Incorrect: The software doesn't change the IP address of the chassis.

  Correct: The software does not change the IP address of the chassis.

  Incorrect: However, it's not connected to the boot images of task sequence packages.

Correct: However, it is not connected to the boot images of task sequence packages.

Conversational

Conversational content includes content for some UI design and microcopy where the product team determines that the nature of the product calls for a more conversational and casual relationship with the customer. Examples of this type of product would be the APEX line of business.

- Use common contractions to sound conversational and create a friendly tone in the user interface. Don't mix contractions and their spelled-out equivalents in UI text. For example, do not use can't and cannot in the same interface.

  Incorrect: We cannot process your request at this time.

  Correct: We can’t process your request right now.

  Incorrect: This page is not available. Try searching for something else.

  Correct: This page isn’t available. Try searching for something else.
- Avoid uncommon or colloquial contractions such as ain't, shan't, mustn't, or y'all, and remember to write as you would speak.

File extensions

Follow these guidelines for using file extensions to describe a file.

- Use all uppercase without a period or an asterisk.

  Incorrect: Copy the *.html files into the directory.

  Correct: Copy the HTML files into the directory.
- If referencing a specific file, provide the exact file name and omit both the and file from the description. If possible, use a DITA element, a monospaced font such as Courier New, or italicized text (in that preferred order) for the filename itself to distinguish it from the body text.

  Incorrect: Edit the example.TXT file.

  Correct: Edit `example.txt`.
- Use a file extension as a modifier to *files* when referencing multiple files of the same type.

  Incorrect: Edit the TXTs.

  Correct: Edit the TXT files.

Change notes

Existing guideline	New guideline	Affected guides

Add an *s* to the extension when describing many of them.	Use a singular extension in all caps as an adjective for a plural noun.	APEX SG
No topic for TWSG	See the topic guidelines. No conflict with Acrolinx.	TWSG

Latin expressions

- Do not use Latin expressions or abbreviations. Replace them with the appropriate English equivalent. Some commonly used examples are included below, but run an Acrolinx check to identify most Latin expressions and their alternatives.

  Incorrect: e.g.

  Correct: for example, such as

  Incorrect: etc.

  Correct: and so forth

  Incorrect: i.e.

  Correct: that is

  Incorrect: ad hoc

  Correct: impromptu, for this purpose

Change notes

Sources:

- **TWSG**

No changes.

Modifiers

Follow these guidelines when using modifiers:

- Avoid using modifiers that do not add value to your sentences.

  Incorrect: The software enables *very* fast backups.

Correct: The software enables fast backups.

- Do not use dangling modifiers. A dangling modifier is a modifier that doesn't apply to anything in the sentence. In the incorrect example, the person downloading the software is omitted.

  Incorrect: Downloading the software, a time-out error may be encountered.

  Correct: Downloading the software, you may encounter a time-out error.

- Ensure that you use the modifier at the correct place in the sentence, as close to the noun it modifies as possible. Misplaced modifiers can cause confusion. In the following example, are we talking about a naked customer, or a hard drive that has been wiped?

  Incorrect: The stripped customer's hard drive can be destroyed.

  Correct: The customer's stripped hard drive can be destroyed.

- Pay special attention to limiting or restricting modifiers such as only. Their placement can alter the meaning of the sentence. The intended meaning in the first example is that the remote site does not have an active, only a passive, copy of the database.

  Incorrect: The remote site *only* has a passive copy of the database.

  Correct: The remote site has *only* a passive copy of the database.

  In this example, it is unclear what cannot be deleted, the files or the disk.

  Incorrect: There are files on the disk that cannot be deleted.

  Correct: The disk includes files that cannot be deleted.

Change notes

No substantive changes made.

Sources:

- TWSG

Singular and plural nouns

Follow these guidelines for using nouns:

- Use the singular version of a noun if you are writing of only one thing; use the plural if you are referring to more than one of a thing. This applies to both UI and technical content.
- Avoid using (s) to indicate both single and plural nouns. Either choose one, or use the format, "When searching for the EXE file or files, do . . . ".

Incorrect: When searching for the EXE *file(s)*, use an asterisk to search on all files with that extension.

Correct: When searching for the EXE *file*, use an asterisk to search on all files with that extension.

Correct: When searching for the EXE *file or files*, use an asterisk to search on all files with that extension.

Parallelism

Parallelism is the repetition of grammatical elements to create rhythm and to increase comprehension by making the content more predictable. Parallelism is useful when you want to emphasize a relationship between two or more ideas. It can also set up a comparison or contrast between two things.

- Use parallelism when presenting a list of items, or when naming together multiple elements.

  Incorrect: Our core values are excellence, trust, transparency, and thinking out of the box.

  Incorrect: Our core values are excellence, trust, transparency, and outside-of-the-box thinking.

  Correct: Our core values are excellence, trust, transparency, and innovation.

  Notice that the first example contains three nouns and a metaphor rather than four nouns. The second example offers four nouns, but the fourth noun is a noun phrase composed of four words. The last example offers four parallel nouns and is easier to read and absorb.

- Write any lists of words, phrases, or clauses that have the same level of importance in the same grammatical form.

  Incorrect: You can use task sequences to capture an operating system image and configure image settings, and they also help to deploy the image on Dell client systems.

  Correct: You can use task sequences to capture an operating system image, configure image settings, and deploy the image on a set of Dell client systems.

  Example of parallelism in lists:

  Incorrect:

  Perform the following actions by using Dell OpenManage Server Administrator:

  - Enable single-server monitoring
  - To view system configuration, health, and performance
  - Turning off and restarting the server

  Correct:

  Perform the following actions by using Dell OpenManage Server Administrator:

  - Enable single-server monitoring

- View system configuration, health, and performance
- Turn off and restart the server

- Pay special attention to correlative conjunctions such as either/or, neither/nor, both/and, and not only/but also. Ensure that these pairs of conjunctions join grammatically parallel sentence elements.

  Incorrect: You can either install the operating system from the captured image or from an original installation source.
  Correct: You can install the operating system either from the captured image or from an original installation source.

Prepositions

Prepositions show direction, time, place, location, or introduce objects before a noun, pronoun, or noun phrase. A preposition is a word or phrase connecting a noun or pronoun to a verb or adjective in a sentence. Typically, it is a small, common word that indicates direction. Adding a preposition can improve readability and avoid ambiguity. The most common prepositions are at, by, for, from, in, of, on, to, and with.

Examples:

at 7 AM

In the morning

On Monday

Some examples of common prepositions used in software product sentences might be:

The agent is *on* the client (shows location).

The replication starts *in* one hour (shows time).

Follow these guidelines for the use of prepositions:

- Include appropriate prepositions to increase clarity in your sentences.

  Incorrect: A Remote Collector application will be installed *to* the system.

  Correct: A Remote Collector application will be installed *on* the system.

- Avoid unnecessary use of prepositions.

  Incorrect: Enter the IP address or hostname of the device and click *on* **Next**.

  Correct: Enter the IP address or hostname of the device and click **Next**.

Pronouns, grammatical person, point of view (POV)

This topic provides general advice on using pronouns, including personal and relative pronouns, and specific exceptions for technical documents and UI content.

Pronouns represent a person—personal pronouns—or thing—relative pronouns.

Personal pronouns include *I, we, you, one, they, he, she,* and *it*. Personal pronouns are inextricably related to grammatical person. First, second, and third person refer to the grammatical distinction between:

- The writer or speaker (pronouns *I, we*) **first person**
- The addressees (pronoun *you, imperative*) **second person**
- Others (pronouns *one, they, he, she, it*) **third person**

Relative pronouns include *that* and *which*.

General guidance for using pronouns

- Make all pronoun references clear and unambiguous.
- Ensure that any pronoun has a clear antecedent.

  Incorrect: The software does not come with a license and **it** must be purchased separately.

  (The antecedent of **it** is unclear; it could refer to either the software or the license)

  Correct: The software does not come with a license. You must purchase the license separately.
- Consider rewriting without pronouns.

Personal pronouns

- Write directly to the audience by using the second person (you, imperative mood).
- Use third person (it, they) for concepts, explanations, facts, and step results.
- Avoid first person (I, we), with specific exceptions for technical documentation and UI content.

In technical documentation:

- Blogs may use the first person (*I, we*).
- White papers allow some use of the first person (*we*, to represent Dell) to recast excessive passive voice into active voice.
- "About the Author" blurbs, which are often written by an author, may exceptionally use the author's gendered pronouns.

In UI content, avoid first and second person in the UI except for the following cases:

- First person (*I, my*) is permitted for:

  Statements from the user's POV, requiring the user's acknowledgement:

  I am not a robot.

  I have read and agree to the Terms and Conditions.

  Proper names of software entities or navigation containers associated with that user:

  My Account

  My Dashboard

- Second person (*you*) is permitted for messages that cannot be worded otherwise:

  Are you sure?

  Forgot your password?

  You can recover those files later.

- Never use gendered third person pronouns (he, him, his or she, her, hers).

  Rewrite with the gender-neutral *they*, if appropriate.

  Consider rewriting without using pronouns.

  Incorrect: After the administrator has granted access to the system, he/she will send an email to the group.

  Better: After administrators have granted access to the system, they will send an email to the group.

  Correct: After granting system access, the administrator will send an email to the group.

Relative pronouns *that* and *which*

- Use relative pronouns (*that* and *which*) correctly. If you struggle with them, consult grammatical guidance for correct use, which is outside the scope of this guideline.
- Relative pronouns may be either restrictive or nonrestrictive.
- A restrictive pronoun is the relative pronoun that introduces a restrictive element, something essential to the meaning of the sentence. Without it, the meaning of the sentence is changed.

  Correct: You can view the system updates *that* were installed in the last 15 days.

- If *that* is the object of the relative clause, it can be left out of the sentence.

  Incorrect: This is the housing *that* is built specifically for the PowerEdge T320 tower server. (*that* is the object of built).

  Correct: This is the housing built specifically for the PowerEdge T320 tower server.

- A nonrestrictive pronoun introduces a nonrestrictive element, something not essential to the sentence's meaning. Removing the element does not change the meaning of the sentence. Use a comma before a relative pronoun that introduces a nonrestrictive element.

Correct: Dell PowerEdge T320, which is a tower server, caters to the SMB market.

Related topics

Imperative mood in Voice and tone as personality.

Change notes

Consolidation and disambiguation of overlapping topics. No substantive changes to any TWSG guidelines. IDS guidelines have been streamlined.

Sources:

TWSG Persons, Pronouns, and Writing for Localization topics

IDS Pronouns topic

Existing guideline	**New guideline**	**Affected guides (APEX SG, TWSG, DDS, IDS)**
Persons topic	Deleted and merged its content here	TWSG
Pronouns topic	Renamed from Pronouns to Pronouns, grammatical person, and point of view	TWSG IDS

Sentences

Follow these guidelines for constructing sentences:

- Keep your sentences short and to the point; your goal is user comprehension. Short sentences also work best for localization.
- When sentences include a phrase that indicates the purpose of an action, state the purpose before the action.

  Incorrect: See the VMware website for more information about ESXi.

  Correct: For more information about ESXi, see the VMware website.
- Do not use fragments or run-ons. Run-ons can generally be corrected by breaking the sentence into two parts, adding a semicolon, or adding a comma and coordinating conjunction. Run-ons can also be corrected by adding a subordinating element to the sentence, as in the example here.

  Incorrect: Each appliance node is equipped with four cards, these cards are called I/O memory cards.

Correct: Each appliance node is equipped with four cards, called I/O memory cards.

Related topics

Voice and tone, for guidelines on sentence length in the context of tone.

NOTE: This topic omits mention of a specific word length, which will be assessed by Acrolinx.

Spelling

Follow these guidelines for spelling words:

- Use American English spelling when writing content. The following table shows general differences between American and British spelling conventions.

American spelling	British spelling
-er (center, meter)	-re (centre, metre)
-ense (defense, offense, license)	-ence (defence, offence, licence)
-ize (specialize, authorize, standardize, categorize)	-ise (specialise, authorise, standardise, categorise
-ll (fulfill, enroll)	-l (fulfil, enrol)
-led, -ling (modeled, canceling, labeling)	-lled, -lling (modelled, cancelling, labelling)
-og (analog, catalog	-ogue (analogue, catalogue)
-or (color, behavior, favor, labor)	-our (colour, behaviour, favour, labour)
-ward (backward, forward, toward)	-wards (backwards, forwards, towards)
-z (analyze)	-s (analyse)

- Some words or phrases might be exceptions to the general convention. If in doubt about spelling or word use, check with Acrolinx, the Merriam-Webster dictionary, or the Chicago Manual of Style.
- If you are writing content specifically for an audience outside the United States, check with your leader to determine if there are unique requirements.

Verb tense: Past, present, future

Verb tense shows when an action occurs.

There are three simple verb tenses:

- Simple past (they wrote)
- Simple present (they write)
- Simple future (they will write)

Users read documentation to perform tasks or gather information, and these activities happen in the present time. Wherever possible, use the simple present tense to describe product behavior, since it is easier to read than the past or future tense.

In general, follow these guidelines for verb tense:

- Use the simple present tense wherever possible. Avoid using the past or future tense.

  Incorrect: If the network did not connect, run the troubleshooting wizard.

  Correct: If the network does not connect, run the troubleshooting wizard.

  Incorrect: The system profile import will not finish when there is a connectivity loss.

  Correct: The system profile import is cancelled when there is a connectivity loss.
- Where there is a dependency in the future on an action performed in the present, reword the content to reflect only present tense.

  Incorrect: Make a note of the image location because you *will* need it later when you mount the virtual media.

  Correct: To mount the virtual media at a later date, make a note of the image location now.
- Use future tense (will) only if it seems more natural for events that will occur later from the users' perspective.

For UI/UX content

- Use past or future tense as required for accurate communication.

  Example: One or more backups *has failed*. Ensure that the backup target is online.
- Keep the tense consistent within your content, be it topic, UI page, document, or application.

  Incorrect: The host system restored the component with errors and will shut down.

  Incorrect: The host system will restore the component with errors and will shut down.

  Correct in technical documentation: The host system restores the component with errors and shuts down.

  Correct in UI/UX content: The host system restored the component with errors and will shut down.

- In Release Notes, do not change an issue description to past tense when the issue moves from the Known issues to the Resolved issues list. It is still the same issue.

  Incorrect:

  Original issue: An unexpected reboot occurs when the ISCSI driver receives an invalid or unsupported asynchronous event notification (AEN)

  Fixed issue: An unexpected reboot *occurred* when the ISCSI driver receives an invalid or unsupported asynchronous event notification (AEN)

  Correct (no change)

  Original issue: An unexpected reboot *occurs* when the ISCSI driver receives an invalid or unsupported asynchronous event notification (AEN)

  Fixed issue: An unexpected reboot *occurs* when the ISCSI driver receives an invalid or unsupported asynchronous event notification (AEN)

Change notes

Minor change from IDS example of when to use future tense. Renamed Verb tense from Tense.

Sources:

- TWSG
- IDS

Existing guideline	New guideline	Affected guides
N/A	Retained guideline permitting past or future tense if needed to reflect user point of view in UI/UX content. Deleted confusing correct/incorrect example.	IDS Tense topic
None	Added present tense guideline (not past tense) for Fixed issues in Release Notes.	TWSG
None	Added guideline for tense in UI/UX writing	IDS Tense topic

Verbs

Follow these guidelines for using verbs:

- A verb must agree in number with its subject. Singular subjects take singular verbs, and plural subjects take plural verbs.

  Examples:

  The LEDs indicate system status.

  A pair of LEDs indicates system status.

- Use the indicative mood for conceptual and reference information. Use the imperative mood for task information.

  Examples:

  The DCDP for ConfigMgr *is* an easy-to-use tool to configure and deploy your Dell client systems. (Indicative mood)

  Select the file that you want to deploy. (Imperative mood)

- Do not use transitive verbs without an object.

  Incorrect: The progress bar displays. (Displays what?)

  Correct: The progress bar displays *the status of the operation*.

Punctuation

Ampersands (&)

- Do not use ampersands.
- Exceptions are brand names and UI labels where spelling out *and* is not possible.

  Examples

  A&W restaurants

  H&M clothing stores

Change notes

TWSG did not include this topic.

Sources:

APEX SG

No changes.

Angle brackets (<>)

- Do not use angle brackets in text, with the exceptions listed below.

  Incorrect: A typical unit approaches this level of operation in *<8%* of operating conditions.

  Correct: A typical unit approaches this level of operation in *less than 8%* of operating conditions.
- Use the angle bracket in mathematical notation, to indicate greater than (>) and less than (<).
- In technical content, use an angle bracket to indicate variables, arguments, or parameter values that the user must replace with actual values.

  Examples

  https://*<instance_hostname>*

  C:\Users*<user_name>*\AppData\Local\Temp

  At the command prompt type: `start <arguments> <switches>`
- Use the > character with a space before and after. Use non-breaking spaces, if possible.
- In non-DITA content: Use an angle bracket when giving navigation instructions, for example: Click File > Save
- In DITA environments, do not manually type the > character when documenting a menu cascade. The <menucascade> and <uicontrol> elements insert the > character between <uicontrol> tags, as shown in the example below.

  Example

  <menucascade><uicontrol>File</uicontrol><uicontrol>Save</uicontrol></menucascade>

  Output: File > Save
- Enclose a variable name with angle brackets and add italics formatting.
- In DITA environments, use the <varname> tag. You must type the angle brackets as the output does not add them to the text. For example:

*<filepath>*https://*<varname>*<instance_hostname>*</varname> </filepath> *

Change notes

TWSG did not include this topic.

Sources: APEX SG

Existing guideline	New guideline	Affected guides

No guidance for when to use angle brackets in text	Added two guidelines for acceptable use: Use the angle bracket in mathematical notation, to indicate greater than (>) and less than (<). In technical content, use an angle bracket to indicate *variables*, *arguments*, or *parameter values* that the user must replace with actual values.	APEX SG New topic for TWSG
	Separated DITA guidance, where angle brackets are used for tags, from guidance for use of angle brackets in text	APEX SG

Colons

There are three primary grammatical uses for a colon: to connect sentences, put emphasis on a word or phrase at the end of a sentence, and to introduce a list of items.

When to use

- Use colons to introduce ordered and unordered lists.

  Correct: You can access the following types of documents on our support site:

  - Reference manuals
  - Owner manuals
  - Installation guides

- Use colons to introduce a list in running text if a complete sentence precedes the list. If the words following the colon form a complete sentence, then capitalize the first character of the word that follows the colon. However, if the words following the colon do not form a complete sentence (dependent clause), then the first character of the word that follows the colon should be lower case unless it is a proper noun.

  Correct: The product design reflects three principles: high availability, application best practices, and hardware abstraction.

- Use a colon between related independent clauses (clauses that can stand alone) to illustrate a point by providing an example.

  Correct: There is one big reason to choose Dell APEX: We provide a unified multicloud experience on technology you trust.

- Use a colon to introduce a figure or table.

  Correct: The following table describes the components that the PowerEdge R630 server supports:

  [table or figure]

- Use a colon at the end of sentences that include the terms as follows and the following.

  Correct: To install the device, run *the following* command: [command]

- Use a colon to separate the title of a work from the subtitle.

  Correct: Play Nice But Win: A CEO's Journey from Founder to Leader

- Use a colon to separate units of time and ratios. There is no space before or after the colon.

  Examples: 12:30 PM, 2:1

- At the end of titles or headings.

  Incorrect (title): Numbers and Measurement Units:

  Correct (title): Numbers and Measurement Units

  Incorrect (heading): When to use:

  Correct (heading): When to use

- Do not use a colon if additional content, such as a note, notice, caution, warning, or sentence, falls between the introductory sentence and the steps or list items. Instead, use a period to end both the initial sentence and the intervening content.

  Incorrect:

  To hot swap a PowerEdge HDD, follow these steps:

  NOTE: To maintain proper system cooling, all empty hard drive slots must have hard drive blanks installed.

  Correct:

  To hot swap a PowerEdge HDD, follow these steps.

  NOTE: To maintain proper system cooling, all empty hard drive slots must have hard drive blanks installed.

- Do not use a colon to separate a noun from its verb, a verb from its object or subject complement, a preposition from its object, or a subject from its predicate.

  Incorrect: The three principles reflected in the product design are: high availability, application best practices, and hardware abstraction.

Correct: The product design reflects three principles: high availability, application best practices, and hardware abstraction.

- Do not use a colon after phrases such as “including” or “especially” as the colon essentially replaces these words, which makes them redundant.

  Incorrect: There are many reasons to buy an Alienware gaming laptop including: high performance, solid quality build, and solid engineering.

  Correct: There are many reasons to buy an Alienware gaming laptop: high performance, solid quality build, and solid engineering.

Commas

The comma represents a pause and is often used to provide clarity by separating two words, phrases, or clauses in a sentence. However, commas should be used judiciously: Do not insert a comma simply because you think that the sentence needs a pause at that point.

- Use a comma before a conjunction (and, but, or, nor, yet, so, for) that separates two independent clauses or two different subjects (software and wizard).

  Incorrect: The software checks each component and the wizard displays the results.

  Correct: The software checks each component, and the wizard displays the results.

- Use a comma after an introductory word or phrases.

  Incorrect: However do not turn off the server while this process is in progress.

  Correct: However, do not turn off the server while this process is in progress.

- Use a serial comma (also known as an Oxford comma) to separate each item in a series of three or more items. The comma is placed before the conjunction (and, but, or, nor, yet, so, for) that separates the series. The series can be made up of words, clauses, or phrases. If one or more clauses contain commas in them, use a semicolon instead of a comma to separate the clauses.

  Incorrect: The ROC feature allows the user to delete, edit and filter devices.

  Correct: The ROC feature allows the user to delete, edit, and filter devices.

  Correct: The ROC feature allows the user to add, delete, and edit; filter and sort; and view.

- Use commas around nonrestrictive elements (words, phrases, or dependent clauses that can be removed without changing the meaning of the sentence).

  Incorrect: The administrator who has additional privileges can make the update.

  Correct: The administrator, who has additional privileges, can make the update.

- Use commas to set off direct quotations. The speaker's name (or pronoun) along with the verb related to the speaking are enclosed in commas.

  Incorrect: Michael Dell states "You don't have to be a genius or a visionary or even a college graduate to be successful. You just need a framework and a dream."

  Correct: Michael Dell states, "You don't have to be a genius or a visionary or even a college graduate to be successful. You just need a framework and a dream."

  Incorrect: "Visionaries have the unique ability to dream of what's possible" he said "and then make it a reality."

  Correct: "Visionaries have the unique ability to dream of what's possible," he said, "and then make it a reality."

- Use commas to set off the year from the rest of the date.

  Incorrect: On February 1, 1984 Michael Dell started a business from his dorm room at the University of Texas in Austin.

  Correct: On February 1, 1984, Michael Dell started a business from his dorm room at the University of Texas in Austin.

- Use commas to set off a title if it follows a person's name.

  Incorrect: Fei-Fei Li, PhD sees Artificial Intelligence (AI) as a tool rather than a substitute for human intelligence.

  Correct: Fei-Fei Li, PhD, sees Artificial Intelligence (AI) as a tool rather than a substitute for human intelligence.

- Use commas to separate numbers into groups of three, starting from the right, in numbers more than four digits long. A comma is optional in numbers four digits long. Exceptions include years, page numbers, and street addresses.

  Examples:

  600

  2,300 [2300]

  144,000

  2,500,000

- Do not use commas to separate bulleted or numbered list items.

  Incorrect:

  1. Log in to PowerStore Manager,
  2. under Hardware, select the appliance that you want to power off,
  3. under More Actions, select Power Down,

  Correct:

  1. Log in to PowerStore Manager.
  2. Under Hardware, select the appliance that you want to power off.

3. Under More Actions, select Power Down.

- Do not use a comma with compound predicates (two or more verbs with a single noun or subject). Adding a comma creates an unwanted pause that causes distance between the subject and the predicate.

  Incorrect: Enter your name in the field, and click Enter.

  Correct: Enter your name in the field and click Enter.

- Do not use commas with restrictive elements (phrase or clause essential to the sentence's meaning).

  Incorrect: Servers, that run slowly, should run diagnostics.

  Correct: Servers that run slowly should run diagnostics.

- Do not use commas to separate clauses that could each stand alone as an independent sentence. To correct a comma splice, separate the clauses with a semi-colon or period, use a connecting word between the clauses, or restructure the sentence.

  Incorrect: An appliance cannot be powered down until all validation checks are passed, review all warnings and recommendations before continuing.

  Correct: An appliance cannot be powered down until all validation checks are passed. Review all warnings and recommendations before continuing.

Change notes

No substantive changes made to existing guidance, but additional guidance provided on edge case situations.

Sources: IDS, APEX SG, TWSG

Change description	Guides affected
Guidance expanded	TWSG, APEX SG

Dashes

Dashes are of two types: the em dash (—) and the en dash (–).

Follow these guidelines for dashes.

- Do not confuse an en dash (–) or an em dash (—) with a hyphen (-). In general, a dash is used to indicate a break in the structure of a sentence or to format a number range, while a hyphen is used to divide a compound word.

For more information about hyphens, see Hyphens.

Em dash (—)

- In running text, use em dashes to set off a parenthetical expression; use one em dash on each side of the expression and do not put a space before or after the em dash. Note that the parenthetical expression between the em dashes could also be set off by commas. To create an em dash on a Windows keyboard, use Alt+0151.

  Example: These commands—which appear only in the new release—include...

- An em dash can also be used to create a break at the end of the sentence. If that is the case, only one dash is necessary. A colon is also acceptable in this case.

  Example: The solution consists of 4,000 users across two sites—Local and Remote.

En dash (–)

- Where space is limited, such as in tables and figures, use an en dash to indicate a range of numbers. Do not include a space on either side of the en dash. To create an en dash on a Windows keyboard, use Alt+0150.

  Correct: slots 1–6

  Incorrect: slots 1 – 6

- Use the en dash for the minus sign.

For more information about using an en dash with numbers, see Number ranges. See also Hyphens.

Ellipses

Follow these guidelines for using ellipses:

- Avoid using ellipses in technical documentation. Use of ellipses indicates an informal tone and might also cause confusion.
- When documenting a user interface, do not include an ellipsis that is part of the interface element label.
- Do not add an ellipsis at the end of a UI element label.
- Use ellipses to show hesitation, faltering speech.
- Use ellipses to convey omissions in quoted text.
- In information messages, use ellipses to show the progress of a task, and do not add a space before the ellipsis.

  Incorrect: Installation in progress …

Correct: Installation in progress…

Exclamation marks

- Do not use exclamation marks except in coding statements and other programming elements.

Hashtags (#)

- Do not use hashtags as a substitute for number.

  Incorrect: #1, #2, #3

  Correct: *Number* 1, *Number* 2, *Number* 3
- An exception is if you are describing a user-interface element that uses a hashtag as a substitute for a number. For example: The system displays #2.
- Another exception is that Hashtags can also be used to communicate the brand story on social media to welcome and build the community. See the Dell Social Playbook, Slide 29 for more information." For overall guidance, see Dell social media policies.

Hyphens

Do not confuse a hyphen (-) with an en dash (–) or an em dash (—). In general, a hyphen is used to divide a compound word, while a dash is used to indicate a break in the structure of a sentence or to format a number range. For more information about dashes, see Dashes.

Follow these guidelines for hyphens.

- Hyphenate compound modifiers to clarify which words modify others in a phrase.

  Correct:

  read-only memory

  near-continuous access

a once-in-a-lifetime small-time operator

world-facing camera-bracket

right kick-stand hinge

Darwin-2 antenna-bracket

right display hinge

- Be careful when a hyphen's location significantly alters the meaning of a phrase. In some cases, it is necessary to include a hyphen in an otherwise unhyphenated compound noun to avoid misinterpretation.

  Incorrect: Those are bad smelling salts.

  Correct (salts that smell bad): Those are bad-smelling salts.

  Correct (smelling salts that are bad): Those are bad smelling-salts.

- Use an en dash instead of a hyphen in a compound adjective when an element already consists of a hyphenated word.

  Incorrect: MS-DOS-compatible *software*

  Correct: MS-DOS–compatible *software*.

- Do not use a hyphen after an adverb that ends in *ly*.

  Incorrect: a highly-unstable *configuration*

  Correct: a highly unstable *configuration*

  Incorrect: a fully-revealed *password*

  Correct: a fully revealed *password*

- Do not use hyphens with words created with prefixes such as anti, multi, non, pre, re, or semi, unless omitting the hyphen would make the words indistinguishable from other words with different meanings or unless they precede a proper noun.

  Correct:

  antistatic

  multiconductor

  multi-institutional

  nonmaskable

  non-Windows

  preinstalled

  re-create

  reenter

  semiconductor

- Do not use hyphens in words such as, ecommerce, email, or website.

- Do not use hyphens with numbers used as quantifiers, unless the numbers would normally be hyphenated.

  Incorrect: The procedure takes one-and-three-quarter hours.

  Correct: The procedure takes one and three-quarter hours.

- Use hyphens with numbers used as part of a compound adjective.

  Incorrect: It is a one and three-quarter hour procedure.

  Correct: It is a one-and-three-quarter-hour procedure.

- Be careful of cases when omitting or including a hyphen significantly alters the meaning of a phrase.

  Correct (she has a grandfather who is great): She has a great *grandfather*.

  Correct (she has a father of a grandfather): She has a *great-grandfather*.

For capitalization of hyphenated words, see Capitalization.

Related topics

Capitalization

Dashes

Number ranges

Change notes

Existing guideline	New guideline	Affected guides
N/A	Added a guideline for hyphens with *ly* adverbs.	All
N/A	Added guidelines for hyphens with numbers.	All

Parentheses

Follow these guidelines for parentheses.

- Use parentheses to introduce acronyms or abbreviations on first use.

  Incorrect: The system provides VBS (virtualization-based security).

  Correct: The system provides virtualization-based security (VBS).

- Use parentheses to present symbols or measurement equivalents. For measurement equivalents, use parentheses around the imperial measure and present it second.

  Incorrect: The password cannot contain characters such as $ or *.

Correct: The password cannot contains characters such as a dollar sign ($) or an asterisk (*).

Incorrect: Each rack unit is 2.14 in. or 54.45 mm high.

Correct: Each rack unit is 54.45 mm (2.14 in.) high.

- Avoid using (s) or (es) to indicate both single and plural nouns. Choose one, use both, or rephrase the sentence.

  Incorrect: When searching for the EXE file(s), …

  Correct: When searching for the EXE file or files, …

  Correct: When searching for an EXE file, …

  Correct: When searching for EXE files, …

  Incorrect: Enter the IP address(es).

  Correct: Enter one or more IP addresses.

- Eliminate any parenthetical information that is not important. Alternatively, rephrase the sentence to include the information in a way that is not parenthetical. Rephrasing a parenthetical sentence often results in simplifying it.

  Incorrect: The system sometimes (so they claim) fails to respond.

  Correct: The system sometimes fails to respond.

  Correct: They claim that the system sometimes fails to respond.

  Incorrect: A total failure has occurred (all PSCs and all vCenter servers failed).

  Correct: All PSCs and vCenter servers have failed.

- Do not use parentheses to separate supplementary information. If necessary, rephrase the sentence. In the following example, the lowercase mailserver cannot be the first word in the sentence.

  Incorrect: The server (mailserver) is offline.

  Correct: The mail server is offline.

  Correct: Status messages indicate that mailserver is offline.

Change notes

Existing guideline	New guideline	Affected guides
Rephrase any sentence that uses parenthetical information in parentheses to use commas or dashes instead.	Eliminate any parenthetical information that is not important. Alternatively, rephrase the sentence to include the information in a way that is not parenthetical.	TWSG
The following subjective commentary about	N/A (Removed)	TWSG, APEX

parentheses: The text in parentheses loses its emphasis when the user scans through it. Parentheses interrupt the flow of the sentence. Parentheses often indicate confusion and a lack of clarity about what you are trying to convey.		

Percent sign (%)

Follow these guidelines for using the percent sign (%):

- Always use the percent sign when following a numeral, with no spacing after the numeral.

  Incorrect: A range of 70 % to 90 % humidity.

  Correct: A range of 70% to 90% humidity.

- Always spell out percent when following a number that is represented by a word.

  Incorrect: The sample size grew by three%.

  Incorrect: The sample size grew by 3 %.

  Correct: The sample size grew by three percent.

For guidelines on using numerals or words to represent numbers, see General number use.

Related topics

General number use

Periods

- End all sentences with a period. Use only one space after a period.

- Follow these guidelines for the correct use of periods:
- Use a period at the end of every declarative sentence including procedural steps.
- In general, end an introductory sentence with a colon. However, if additional text appears between the introductory sentence and the list being introduced, use periods at the end of the introductory sentence and at the end of any other sentences before the list.

  Example:

  Select from the following supported Dell PowerEdge systems. When you select from one of the listed systems, the Dell DVS Simplified 1020 software is not factory-installed.
- In lists, insert periods at the end of complete sentences.
- Insert a period at the end of all items in a list if at least one of the items in the list completes the introductory sentence.

  Example:

  During the meeting, employees made the following suggestions for improving the workspace:

  - Add offices.
  - Reconfigure existing spaces to suit our business unit's needs. Many vacant cubicles could be removed to support flex workspaces.
  - Add touchdown stations. Touchdown stations give remote workers a place to work if they come into the office.
  - Encourage employees to work from home.
- Include a period before filename extensions only when referring to actual filenames.

  Example:

  Save your settings in the `config.lxe` file.
- Extensions used to refer to file types should be capitalized and without a period.

  Example:

  Settings are saved in LXE files.
- If the list items are complete sentences, then use a period even if the sentence has fewer words.

Do not use periods:

- At the end of headings, sub-headings, or titles.
- For fragments.
- In ellipses or at the end of a sentence that ends with an ellipsis.
- At the end of a sentence that ends with an abbreviation that already has a period.
- If the list items are only fragments or short phrases unless the introduction to the list is an incomplete sentence and the list items complete the sentence.
- In uppercase abbreviations.

Examples:

USA

GMT

Change notes

Existing guideline	New guideline	Affected guides (TWSG, APEX SG, DDS, IDS)
N/A	Do not use a period: … at the end of a sentence that ends with an ellipsis. At the end of a sentence that ends with an abbreviation that already has a period.	TWSG

Pipes

A pipe (|) is a vertical bar used in commands and programming languages as a delimiter or separator.

- Always insert a space before and after the pipe.

Question marks

- A question mark is used at the end of a direct question.
- Use questions sparingly and only under exceptional circumstances.
- Do not use more than one question mark (???) or pair it with an exclamation point (?!).
- When writing UI microcopy, use a question to verify that the user acknowledges that they want to delete something. In this context, see also Pronouns, grammatical person, and point of view.

  Example:

Deleting this adapter will remove all associated devices. Are you sure you want to delete this adapter?

Change log

New topic for TWSG and APEX SG.

Quotation marks

Follow these guidelines for quotation marks.

- Use for spoken words or short, quoted sentences, if applicable. Most technical writing does not contain quotes.
- Place commas and periods inside closing quotation marks. Place other punctuation marks such as colons, semicolons, question marks, and exclamation marks outside closing quotation marks, unless they are part of the quote.
- Where possible, always use smart (curly) quotation marks, not vertical (straight) quotation marks.
- Do not use for emphasis, defining or introducing a word, or describing a command to enter. Instead, use italicized or bolded text, a monospaced font face, or an appropriate DITA element, if applicable.

  Incorrect: This software release introduces the term “binary encryption.”

  Correct: This software release introduces the term *binary encryption*.

  Incorrect: Run the command “shutdown -r now”.

  Incorrect: Run the command “shutdown -r now.”

  Correct: Run the command *shutdown -r now*.
- Do not use around blockquotes. For more information about blockquotes, see Blockquote.
- Do not use as a replacement for inch. Always spell out the word.

  Incorrect: a 3.5” drive

  Correct: a 3.5-inch drive

Related topics

Blockquotes

Change notes

Existing guideline	New guideline	Affected guides
Use quotation marks in coding	N/A (Removed)	TWSG

statements and other programming elements.		
N/A	Do not use “ as a replacement for *inch*. Always spell out the word.	All

Semicolons

Follow these guidelines for using semicolons:

- Avoid using semicolons as they are too formal for most web, UI, and technical writing content. Instead, break down complex sentences into simple ones by applying the principles of minimalism to keep sentences short.

  Incorrect: A solid white light indicates the power-on state; a blinking white light indicates the sleep state.

  Correct: A solid white light indicates the power-on state. A blinking white light indicates the sleep state.

If used sparingly, semicolons may be acceptable in white papers and personal blogs.

Slashes

Follow these guidelines for slashes.

- Do not use a slash to express alternatives such as in the constructions either/or or and/or. Using a slash in this way can cause confusion in translation. Instead, write just and or just or, or rephrase the sentence to express both.

  Incorrect: The LEDs indicate fault and/or activity on the disk.

  Correct: The LEDs indicate a fault or activity on the disk.

  Correct: The LEDs indicate a fault, activity, or both a fault and activity on the disk.

- Use a slash in constructions of phrases that are commonly used across the industry.

  Correct:

  client/server

  read/write

- Where you must use a slash, do not place spaces around the slash.
- Do not use a slash to indicate omitted words or letters.

  Incorrect: w/o

  Correct: without
- Do not use a slash in fractions. Instead, use decimal numbers or write them out.

  Incorrect: 1/5 of our customers

  Correct: one-fifth of our customers

  Correct: 20% of our customers

  Incorrect: 1 ½

  Correct: 1.50

  Correct: one and a half
- In pathnames, use the same forward slash (/) or backward slash (\) that is used by the operating system being documented.

Special characters

Special characters are any character not considered a letter or a number. These characters include #, &, @, %, ^, and any punctuation.

- Do not use special characters in button labels, CTAs, action menus, headings, or titles, with the exception of using a colon to separate a title from its subtitle.

  Correct: Cooking and Baking in Greece: Fried Chicken in the Ancient World

Numbers and measurement units

Alphabetizing letters, numbers, and symbols

Follow these guidelines for alphabetizing letters, numbers, and symbols:

- When alphabetizing lines of characters for presentation formats such as tables and glossaries, put symbols first, sorted in ascending ASCII (American Standard Code for Information Exchange) order, then numerals, sorted in ascending order, and then letters, sorted in ascending order. If two letter entries are identical aside from case, put the uppercase variant before the lowercase variant.

  Correct:

  !
  and
  (
  1
  4
  7
  11
  Cryptography
  D
  d
  software
  System
  Terminal

  Be aware that some formatting systems are beyond individual control. For example, the Tridion output of DITA glossaries presents entries in a significantly different order. In such situations, do not sort the entries you have control over to match. Instead, sort them according to the guidelines and allow the inconsistency.

Change notes

Existing guideline	New guideline	Affected guides
A different sorting order was used.	A new sorting order is used. (minor phrasing change)	All
N/A	Do not sort entries you have control over to match the sorting of entries you have no control over. Instead, follow the guideline and allow inconsistency.	All

Currency

Follow these guidelines for currency:

- Use numerals and the dollar symbol ($) prefix without a space.

  This is an exception to the general rule to use words to represent numbers *zero* through *nine*. Currency is normally only referenced in UI elements and Marketing or Sales content where shorter phrasing is preferred.

  Incorrect: 8 dollars

  Correct: $8

- For currency that is not a whole dollar amount, use two decimal places to represent the cents.

  Incorrect: $5.2

  Correct: $5.20

- For currency that is less than a dollar, include a zero before the decimal with the general syntax and do not use the word cents.

  Incorrect: $.40

  Incorrect: 40 cents

  Correct: $0.40

- Use commas with four or more digits.

  Incorrect: $1000

  Correct: $1,000

- If you must use the currency code (USD) prefix, use a space, and do not combine it with the dollar symbol.

  Using the currency code might be required if currencies from two or more different locales are being documented in the same sentence, paragraph, or user interface element.

  Incorrect: USD$300

  Incorrect: $300 USD

  Correct: USD 300

To localize currency for other locations, see Locale format standards.

Related topics

Decimals

General number use

Dates

This topic provides general guidelines for representing dates in technical or UI content.

It is important to flag information that requires globalization to your engineering team to avoid mishandling. Dates, phone numbers, addresses, names, and currency all rely on APIs to internationalize by locale. For more information on globalization requirements, see Locale Format Standards.

When we speak of date format, we typically speak in terms of *long form* and *short form*:

Form	Example
Long	July 18, 1958
Short	m/d/yyyy, or 7/18/1958

- Spell out the date when possible for maximum clarity and accessibility. It is helpful to include the day for events, announcements, or scheduled maintenance, especially when the event spans multiple days.
- Use the short form for interactive inputs for UI design, including text inputs and date pickers, as it is preferred for internationalization.
- Use the term *location* instead of *country*. As a global business, Dell Technologies strives to remain neutral in geopolitical dialogue.
- Always present the year as a 4-digit number in both the long and short forms.

  Incorrect: 4/12/01

  Correct: 4/12/2001
- Avoid referring to seasons, which differ by northern and southern hemispheres. Use months or quarters.
- Avoid using the prefix *bi* to mean either two or twice. Bimonthly can mean either every two months or twice a month whereas *biannual* means twice a year.

  Incorrect: *biannual* or *bimonthly*

  Correct: *twice a year* or *every two months*
- Relative dates are useful for accessing recent information in widgets or filters related to short, approximate periods of time, such as *n days* or *n weeks*. They are not replacements for exact dates when you require specificity, such as purchase dates or version histories. If you need an exact reference, use an absolute date.

- Relative dates are less useful when the number isn't simplified within a larger increment of time. Always update the increment—from minutes to hours, for example—to help the user understand the approximate time as intuitively as possible. Rely on dynamic handling to accurately calculate increments that aren't fixed intervals, such as months, which can range from 28 to 31 total days.

  Incorrect: Next 525,600 minutes, 144 hours, 365 days ago, next three months

  Correct: Next year, 6 days ago, a year ago, next quarter

Long form

Long form includes the day and month, spelled out fully.

- Use the long form in emails and in block quotes, cards, and component copy in UI content design. If the date is inline with copy or standing alone, write it in long form. Drop the leading zero for days.

  Example: Thursday, April 2, 2001 or April 2, 2001

- In compact spaces such as tables, the abbreviated form may be used.

  Example: Apr 2, 2001

- Use the accepted abbreviation according to locale. As an example, use the three-letter abbreviation when abbreviating the month or day in the United States. It is not necessary to use punctuation.

  Incorrect: Thurs or Au.

  Correct: Thu or Aug

- Use plain numbers for dates (cardinal) instead of adding -nd, -th or -st (ordinal).

  Incorrect: October 21st, 2023

  Correct: October 21, 2023

Short form

When using short form, state the expected format in the label to ensure it is always visible to the user (Form instructions; W3C's Web Accessibility Initiatives). In the United States, the expected format is m/d/yyyy.

  Example: 4/2/2001

  Do not add the expected format as placeholder text in a UI text field because it disappears once users type into the input.

- It is common practice for technical documentation to include the leading zeros in short form dates. However, these may be dropped depending on the audience and context.

- Using slashes or hyphens depends on location. For example, the expected format in the United States is m/d/yyyy, whereas in South Korea it is yyyy-mm-dd. Refer to localization guidelines to find priority locale-based formatting requirements.

File naming

- Use the International Organization for Standardization (ISO) 8601 extended numerical format for file names within repositories where files are automatically sorted by ascending or descending order. Use hyphens to separate the parts of the date.

  Example: 2014-05-25

- If hyphens are not allowed within the file name, use the ISO 8601 basic format.

  Example: 20140525

Dates in tables

- Long form is clearest and should be used when possible. If space does not allow for the long form, use the abbreviated date.

  Example: Dec 26, 2023

- Use short form only if the space does not allow for the preferred long or abbreviated forms.

  Example: 12/26/2023

- Left-align dates in tables for readability. Even though dates appear as numeric information in their short form, they are qualitative numbers used for reference rather than quantitative comparison.

  Example of long form:

Invoice	Date
ATX-78702	Tuesday, October 31, 2023
EDS-98020	Wednesday, September 27, 2023
STP-33702	Thursday, November 23, 2023

  Example of abbreviated form:

Invoice	Date
ATX-78702	Oct 31, 2023
EDS-98020	Sep 27, 2023
STP-33702	Nov 23, 2023

  Example of short form:

Invoice	Date
ATX-78702	10/31/2023
EDS-98020	9/27/2023

STP-33702 11/24/2023

Sources

Y2K Repair Bill: $100 Billion (Washington Post)

The Year 2000: Y2K (Library of Congress)

Date-Input Form Fields (NN/g)

Form Instructions (WCAG 2.1)

ISO 8601 Date and time format

Decimals

Follow these guidelines for decimals to ensure accuracy, clarity, and consistency:

- Always use numerals to express numbers containing a decimal, unless the number is less than one and you are expressing it as a fraction.

  Incorrect: five and three-quarter inches

  Correct: 5.75 inches

  Incorrect: It is .75 complete.

  Correct: It is three-quarters complete.

- For numbers less than one, include a zero before the decimal.

  Incorrect: .55 inches

  Correct: 0.55 inches

- When expressing a group of numbers, always express decimals to at least two decimal places, unless all the numbers represented are whole numbers or the decimal number is associated with something that is commonly known to only have a single decimal place.

  Incorrect: 0.5 inches

  Correct: 0.50 inches

  Incorrect: a 3.50-inch drive

  Correct: a 3.5-inch drive

  Correct (when in a group with a non-whole number): 30.00

Correct (when in a group of all whole numbers): 30

NOTE: Depending on your group's standard, a group of numbers can be a portion of a wider group, for example, a row of specifications within a table of specifications. In such scenarios, the row of specifications should use consistent decimal placing but does not necessarily have to use the same decimal placing as the wider group of the rest of the table.

- Express numbers to more than two decimal places when such precision is required.

  Example: There is a guaranteed reliability rating of 99.999%.

- When rounding decimals, round decimal components less than 5 down and decimal components greater than or equal to 5 up.

  Correct (rounded from 12.434): 12.43

  Correct (rounded from 12.435): 12.44

Related topics

Fractions

General number use

Change notes

Existing guideline	New guideline	Affected guides
N/A	Use only a single decimal place if the thing being described is commonly known to only have a single decimal place.	All

Fractions

Follow these guidelines for fractions.

- Spell out simple fractions of less than one, using two words joined with a hyphen.

  Incorrect: It is three quarters complete.

  Correct: It is three-quarters complete.

- Do not use a hyphen if the parts are being emphasized individually.

  Incorrect: The fiscal year is divided into four-quarters.

  Correct: The fiscal year is divided into four quarters.

- If the spelled-out fraction requires more than two words, hyphenate only the part of the fraction that is a two-digit numeral.

  Incorrect: two-twenty-fifths

  Correct: two twenty-fifths

- Express fractions that precede a unit of measurement and numbers that contain a whole number and a fraction using decimal numerals instead.

  Incorrect: Turn it three-and-a-half times.

  Correct: Turn it 3.50 times.

  Incorrect: five and three-quarter inches

  Correct: 145 mm (5.75 inches)

Related topics

Decimals

General number use

Follow these guidelines for using numbers.

Use words to represent numbers

- For whole numbers *zero* through *nine*, unless the number represents currency or units of measure.

  Incorrect: 4 hard drives

  Correct: four hard drives

- For all numbers beginning a sentence.

  NOTE: List items of sentence fragments and automatically generated UI status and search-result messages are not considered sentences. Sentence fragments and automatically generated UI messages can start with numerals rather than words.

  Incorrect: 15 infrastructure nodes provide a range of services.

  Correct: Fifteen infrastructure nodes provide a range of services.

- For all fractions of numbers less than one.

  Incorrect: .75 of the systems failed.

  Correct: Three-quarters of the systems failed.

Incorrect: The fiscal year is divided into .25.

Correct: The fiscal year is divided into quarters.

Use numerals to represent numbers

- For numbers 10 and higher, unless beginning a sentence. However, use numerals to represent all numbers that represent currency.

  Correct: 10 hard drives

  Correct: Twelve sessions were active.

- For units of measure, including measurements of time, unless beginning a sentence.

  Correct: 2 ft

  Correct: 5 s

  Correct: Two minutes into the process, an error message appears.

- In lists or text that contain a collection of numbers, where some numbers are less than or equal to nine and some are greater than nine.

  Incorrect: The PowerEdge VRTX can support up to two PowerEdge M820 servers and up to 16 PowerEdge M520 or M620 servers.

  Correct: The PowerEdge VRTX can support up to 2 PowerEdge M820 servers and up to 16 PowerEdge M520 or M620 servers.

- When using a number as a modifier.

  Incorrect: eight-port switch

  Correct: 8-port switch

- When expressing a ratio.

  Incorrect: The compression ratio can be as high as twenty-two:one.

  Correct: The compression ratio can be as high as 22:1.

- When expressing a decimal.

  Incorrect: three and a half inches

  Correct: 3.50 inches

- When the number is an identifier.

  Incorrect: SSD slot one

  Correct: SSD slot 1

General guidelines

- If a group of numbers includes numbers where otherwise some would be expressed in words and others in numerals, follow the standard based on the majority of a given value range or use the standard that makes the most sense in context.

  Incorrect: The numbers used are two, five, eight, and 12.

  Correct: The numbers used are two, five, eight, and twelve.

  Incorrect: Empty and catalog storage bins nine, 11, 14, and 16.

  Correct: Empty and catalog storage bins 9, 11, 14, and 16.

  Incorrect: The allowed range is two to 12.

  Correct: The allowed range is 2 to 12.

- When two categories of numbers are next to each other, spell out the numbers in one of the categories.

Correct: two 3.5-inch hard drives

Correct: The solution supports sixteen 2-cable networks.

- When two numbers appear next to each other and they are both ten or greater or space is limited, both numbers can appear numerically with an x between them.

  Correct: 2 x 3.5-inch hard drives

  Correct: The solution supports 16 x 12-cable networks.

- Represent numbers that appear in a UI as they appear in the interface.
- Express very large numbers with both a numeral and a word, even if the numeral is less than 10, unless beginning a sentence.

  Correct: 1 million

  Correct: 100 million

  Correct: Ten million users were surveyed.

- Use commas with four or more digits.

  Incorrect: 1000

  Correct: 1,000

  Correct: The factory has more than 10,000 units.

- Do not use commas with numerals for page numbers, years, or addresses.

  Correct: Turn to page 1000.

  Correct: When represented by only two digits, the year 2000 is indistinguishable from the year 1900.

  Correct: The office is located at 1328 Main Street.

- When using a unit of measurement, follow the requirement of the region where the document is distributed and use either only the metric system or both the metric and imperial systems. If the content is written for a North American audience, but intended to support a global audience, use both metric and imperial systems.
- When writing both systems of measurement, write the metric system (Celsius, meter, centimeter) first, followed by the imperial system (Fahrenheit, foot, inch) within parentheses.

  Correct (for metric system only): Certain configurations of this server have been validated to perform at temperatures as high as 45°C.

  Correct (for both metric and imperial systems): Certain configurations of this server have been validated to perform at temperatures as high as 45°C (113°F).

Related topics

Currency

Decimals

Fractions

Number ranges

Numbers as hyphenated modifiers

Ordinal numbers

Change notes

Existing guideline	New guideline	Affected guides
N/A	All numbers that represent currency should always be represented by numerals.	All
N/A	Use the word or numeral standard that applies to the majority of a given value in a mixed group rather than applying a mixed standard.	All
N/A	Sentence fragments and automatically generated UI messages can start with numerals.	All

Number ranges

Follow these guidelines for using number ranges.

- Use to or through to separate a range of numbers.

  Incorrect: Chassis 12–14 are installed in rack 7.

  Correct: Chassis 12 to 14 are installed in rack 7.

  Correct: Chassis 12 through 14 are installed in rack 7.

- If space in a table is limited, optionally use an en dash to separate a range of numbers.

  Correct: 32–64 MB

- Use an en dash instead of a hyphen to indicate the minus sign or a negative number.

  Incorrect: -12 VDC

  Correct: –12 VDC

- In a range of numbers, include the unit of measure or its abbreviation only after the last item.

  Incorrect: 115 volts (V) to 230 volts (V)

  Correct: 115 to 230 volts (V)

  Incorrect: 115 V to 230 V

  Correct: 115 to 230 V

- If a range crosses between positive and negative, represent the range by using both to and an en dash.

  Incorrect: 115– –230 V

  Correct: 115 to –230 V

  Incorrect: –230 V–115 V

  Correct: –230 V to 115 V

Change notes

Existing guideline	New guideline	Affected guides
Use *to* for a range of numbers up to but not including the last number. Use *through* for a range of numbers up to and including the last number.	Use *to* or *through* for a range of numbers up to and including the last number.	TWSG, APEX SG

Numbers as hyphenated modifiers

Follow these guidelines for using numbers as hyphenated modifiers.

- Use numerals for hyphenated modifiers that describe quantity.

  Incorrect: six-pin connector

  Correct: 6-pin connector

  Incorrect: four three-wire prongs

  Incorrect: 4 3-wire prongs

  Correct: four 3-wire prongs

- If a hyphenated modifier begins a sentence always spell it out or rephrase the sentence.

  Incorrect: 3-port GbE switches are included.

  Correct: Three-port GbE switches are included.

  Correct: The package includes 3-port GbE switches.

Ordinal numbers

Follow these guidelines for using ordinal ranges.

- Spell out ordinal numbers first through ninth.

  Incorrect: Insert the memory module into the 3rd slot.

  Correct: Insert the memory module into the third slot.

- Use numerals for ordinal numbers 10th and higher.

  Incorrect: Before lifting the faceplate, remove the twelfth and thirteenth screws.

  Correct: Before lifting the faceplate, remove the 12th and 13th screws.

- If multiple ranges of ordinal numbers are used, either spell them all out or use numerals, depending on the majority.

  Incorrect: Empty the first, second, 11th, 14th, 15th, and 17th boxes.

  Correct: Empty the 1st, 2nd, 11th, 14th, 15th, and 17th boxes.

  Incorrect: Replace the first, second, and 11th resistors.

  Correct: Replace the first, second, and eleventh resistors.

- If different categories of ordinal numbers are used, spell out one category and use numerals for the other category:

Incorrect: The first and second steps involve the fifth and sixth systems.

Correct: The first and second steps involve the 5th and 6th systems.

Phone numbers

It is important to flag information that requires globalization to your engineering team to avoid mishandling. Dates, phone numbers, addresses, names, and currency all rely on APIs to internationalize by locale. For more information on globalization requirements, see Locale format standards.

- Follow locale format standards to choose the correct format based on location. In the United States, the expected format uses hyphens, not parentheses, periods, or spaces. The country code is not always necessary but can be included for reference and for global audiences.

  Incorrect: 512.459.2222

  Incorrect: (512)-459-2222

  Incorrect: (512) 459-2222

  Correct: 512-459-2222

  Correct: +1-512-459-2222

- When asking a user to enter their phone number, state the expected format in the label or helper text to assist users in formatting their entry correctly (Form instructions; W3C's Web Accessibility Initiatives). When applicable, apply a mask to the input to automatically format the entry based on locale.

Time

It is important to flag information that requires globalization to your engineering team to avoid mishandling. Dates, phone numbers, addresses, names, and currency all rely on APIs to internationalize by locale. For more information on globalization requirements, see Locale format standards.

- Representing time using a 12-hour clock or a 24-hour clock is determined by locale requirements. For example, the United States uses a 12-hour clock while Brazil uses a 24-hour clock.
- Use eastern time (ET) all year round. Do not use eastern standard time (EST) or eastern daylight time (EDT) as these only occur during certain periods of the calendar year. Apply this rule across all time zones.

Incorrect: 1:00 PM CST

Correct: 1:00 PM CT

- Capitalize AM and PM without periods. Ensure there is a space between the time in numerals and the abbreviation.

  Incorrect: 11:00 p.m.

  Incorrect: 11:00 P.M.

  Incorrect: 11:00 pm

  Correct: 1:00 PM

- Time is shown in hours and minutes. If there is a use case that requires more specificity, such as audit logs, showing the time down to the second is unnecessary.
- If indicating a time range, use AM or PM after each time. Write out the range with *to* where possible, *2:00 PM to 3:00 PM.* Using an en dash within the range, *2:00 PM–3:00 PM*, is acceptable where there are space constraints. Do not use a hyphen or em dash.
- Use numerals to indicate time, except for noon and midnight. Use *noon* and *midnight* to represent 12:00 PM and 12:00 AM, respectively, to make it clearer.
- If indicating both a date and time, separate them with the word *at* instead of a comma.

  Example: December 26, 2024 at 1:00 PM CT

Change notes

Existing guideline	New guideline	Affected guides
Use a.m. and p.m. in time of day	Change formatting from a.m. to AM. Note that Acrolinx does not check for this.	TWSG

Units of measurement

Some items require the use of a unit of measurement. This is done to clarify the magnitude of the item in question. Items that require unit of measurement include time, distance, temperature, volume, size, pixels, and power. Localization considerations impact many of these units of measurement dealt within these standards, for details on localization, see Locale format standards.

- Use a unit of measure for clarity

- Units of measure provide information on how an object is measured (its magnitude). For example, if 'Run time' is listed for a job, a value of 3 has a very different meaning if it is seconds, minutes, hours, days, or years.

  Incorrect: Run time: 3
  Correct: Run time: 3 hours
  Incorrect: Volume size: 126
  Correct: Volume size: 126 TB

- Use numerals rather than spelling out the value for units of measurement, even when the number is less than 10

  Incorrect: Five GB
  Correct: 5 GB

- When space is limited or a geographic region exclusively uses a particular measurement system, show the region's preferred/required measurement system (metric or imperial). If space allows, you may use both the imperial and metric measurements, with the imperial measurement listed first followed by the metric measurement in parentheses ("75°F (23.89°C)").

  Exceptions to showing both systems of measurement include:

  - A region, such as EMEA or India, which use the metric system exclusively.
  - When localization is possible, and the GUI can show units of measurements based on a user's region. In this case, Dell recommends that you provide the ability to change the units of measurements within the software.

  Incorrect: only showing "23.89° C" in the United States
  Correct: showing either "75°F (23.89°C)" or "75°F" in the United States

- Format units of measurement appropriately, such as spelled out, abbreviated, or symbols.

  See the NIST Guide for the Use of the International System of Units for more details.

- Generally, spell out time units of measure (seconds, minutes, and years). When using abbreviations do not follow the abbreviation with a period. Exception only if the abbreviations can be confused with other common words (e.g., "5.25 in.").

  Incorrect: 3 y
  Correct: 3 years

  Incorrect: 1 GB.
  Correct: 1 GB

  Incorrect: 4 percent
  Correct: 4%

  Incorrect: 5 in
  Correct: 5 in.

Singular and plural units

- Abbreviated units should never be pluralized by adding an ‘s’. An abbreviation represents both singular and plural forms. With spelled out units only add an ‘s’ when the unit of measure is greater than 1.

  Incorrect: 5 cms
  Correct: 5 cm

  Incorrect: 5 second
  Correct: 5 seconds

- In most cases, include a space between the value and the unit of measurement. Exceptions apply for percentage, temperature—measured in degrees, pixels, and when referring to the size or configuration of a rack server—as in *Mount the 1U rack mount server in U41*. Avoid placing the value and unit of measurement on separate lines. Use a non-breaking space between them if necessary.

  Incorrect: 1GB
  Correct: 1 GB

  Incorrect: 2 U
  Correct: 2U

- Avoid using a slash for combined units of measurement. Use a combined abbreviation or spell out the measurement if there is enough space.

  Incorrect: 2/week
  Correct: 2 times per week or twice per week

  Incorrect: 10 MB/s
  Correct: 10 MBps

- Use appropriate unit size.

- Use the unit of measurement that is appropriate for having the smallest whole value for the item in question. For example, kilograms or pounds are more appropriate for large product weights, such as a server. Whereas grams or ounces may be more appropriate for small hardware and peripheral products, such as a microchip. This guideline follows the International System of Units (SI) convention of avoiding numbers less than 0.1 and greater than 1,000 when you can use a greater or lesser alternative unit.

  Incorrect: 525,600 minutes
  Correct: 1 year

  Incorrect: 1,000 MB
  Correct: 1 GB

Three-dimensional measurements (height x width x depth)

- When you write three-dimensional measurements—height, width, depth—in a *number by number* format use a lowercase x, with a space on either side, to indicate *by*. If all three dimensions are given, always put them in height-width-depth order.

  Incorrect: 10 inches high by 12 inches wide by 20 inches deep

  Correct: 10” x 12” x 20”

Dell's most common units of measurement and approved abbreviations

NOTE: If space allows, fully spelled out versions of these abbreviations can be used:

Technical specification units:

Ampere: A
Ampere-hour: Ah or AHr
Dots per inch: dpi
Gigabit: Gb
Gigabits per second: Gbps
Gigabytes: GB
Gigabytes per second: GBps
Gigahertz: GHz
Hertz: Hz
Kilobit: Kb
Kilobits per second: Kbps
Kilobyte: KB
Kilobytes per second: KBps
Kilohertz: kHz
Kilowatt: kW
Kilowatt-hour: kWh or kWhr
Megabit: Mb
Megabits per second: Mbps
Megabyte: MB
Megabytes per second: MBps
Megapixel: MP
Revolutions per minute: rpm
Terabit: Tb
Terabits per second: Tbps
Terabytes: TB
Terabytes per second: TBps
Watt: W
Watt-hour: Wh or WHr

Length:

Centimeter: cm
Foot: ft or '
Inch: in. or ''
Kilometer: km

Mile: mi
Millimeter: mm
Yard: yd

Weight/mass:

Gram: g
Kilogram: kg
Milligram: mg
Ounce: oz
Pound: lb

Time:

Preference is to fully spell out.

Hour: hr
Minute: min

NOTE: This abbreviation is sometimes used to indicate the word *minimum*. Using it for both purposes in one context may confuse people.)

Month: mo
Second: sec

***Year*:**

Yr

Temperature:

degrees Celsius: °C
degrees Fahrenheit: °F
kelvins: K

Document components

Understanding the major components of a document and the names and standards for each is essential for writers, whether you are authoring a Tridion publication, a marketing brochure, a white paper, or a web page.

This section provides general standards and, where needed for clarity, authoring-tool specifics. CE&T writers: See the CE&T KB for comprehensive authoring tool details.

Title page

- If your document has a title page, ensure that the title page includes all the information required by that document type.

NOTE: For CE&T documents, most title page content is populated or prompted for automatically by the template you choose, whether a Tridion publication, a solution document, or a white paper. See CE&T KB for comprehensive authoring tool details. For other content, check with your team, writing manager, or organization. The one standard across all Dell is that the title page title should be in title case.

Document title

- Use title-case capitalization for document titles. For more information about title-case capitalization, see Capitalization.
- Do not use a sentence as a title.

Regulatory model number

- Add a regulatory model number, type, or series on the title page only if it is a regulatory requirement for that document. For information about how to populate regulatory information, consult your team, writing manager, or organization.

Legend for notes, cautions, and warnings

- The legend for notes, cautions, and warnings is automatically generated in Tridion documents. In non-Tridion documents, use the legend that is available in the template.

Copyright statement

Follow these guidelines for copyright statements:

- Tridion documents: The current copyright statement is automatically provided when you use one of the Tridion template map objects, although you must manually update the publication year or publication year range in the map by using a variables topic.
- For Dell, Dell EMC, and Dell Technologies-branded vendor documents, see this KB Legal Operations - Copyright Notice (service-now.com) if Dell owns the copyright per the contract with the vendor.
- For non-Dell, non-Dell EMC, and non-Dell Technologies-branded vendor documents, consult your writing manager.

- In general, for sustaining updates to publications, the starting date of the copyright statement is the year the publication is released, and the ending date is the year the publication was last updated. For example, if a publication was released in 2022, and the last update was made in 2024, the copyright would be *2022—2024*.

Month and year

- Include the month and year in the yyyy-mm format above or below the copyright statement. Ensure that you include the correct release month and year of the document. The release date can differ depending on the publication type and your group's standard.

  Examples:

  Printed documents: The date the document is released to print.

  Online documents requiring translation: The date the document is released to translation.

  Online documents not requiring translation: The date the document is posted or otherwise released.

Part numbers

- Part numbers are generally deprecated in Tridion documents. Check with your writing manager if your document requires part numbers.

Titles, headings, and headers

About titles, headings, and headers

Although sometimes the terms are used interchangeably, titles, headings, and headers play different roles in a document:

Titles apply to an entire document, which may be a Tridion publication ("book title"), a web page, a white paper, or a solution document, and, in Tridion documents with chapters, to chapters and to topics. Documents, chapters, and topics have titles. In some authoring tools, a web page title is applied with an HTML Heading 1 tag, but it is still functionally a title. Tables and figures have titles, also known as captions. Capitalization standards vary with what is being titled.

Headings are within a topic and flag a section of text to call attention to the organization and content of the topic. They provide important signposts for the user. In Tridion, headings within a topic may be applied with DITA tags such as *sectiontitle* but that's just a tag name; structurally and functionally they are still headings.

Headers are repeating elements in a publication or other content that appear at the top of a "page," much as footers may appear at the bottom. To determine what standard applies, identify what your team is talking about when it talks about *header*:

- A *heading* (within a page)?
- A *title* (at the top of a page)?
- A *message header* (the title for a message)?
- Or an actual *header*, a repeated element in a publication or web page? Depending on the authoring tool, header content may be input directly by the writer or, as in CE Tridion content, automatically filled in with the contents of another element like a book title or a chapter title. In web pages, the header may contain navigational elements and icons as well as text.

NOTE:

- See CE&T KB for comprehensive authoring tool details.
- "Headline" is a term used about marketing content and the capitalization standard depends on their usage.
- In Dell Technologies Tridion-authored output, because rendering of DITA elements to published HTML or PDF depends on the transform, be sure to:
- Avoid equating an HTML H1 tag with any particular source element; HTML tag levels depend on the element's position in the output.
- Remember that in CE PDF output, topic titles typically are rendered as section headings within chapters.

Guidelines

Follow these guidelines when creating titles, headings, and headers:

- Ensure that they accurately describe the content they represent. This helps users who use screen readers skim to find desired content.
- Be brief. The longer the text, the more users will have to read or listen to find what they need.
- Do not end a title, a heading, or a header with a period or colon.
- Avoid widowed headings—headings one after the other without text between the two. Also, if the text that separates the headings is insignificant, one of the headings is probably unnecessary.
- (CE) For task topics or sections, use headings that begin with imperatives not gerunds.

  Incorrect: Installing Dell devices

  Correct: Install Dell devices

Capitalization rules for titles and headings in documents

Component	Capitalization rule	Examples
Document title, such as book title, or a web page title—called an *H1 header* in some UI authoring tools	Title case	• SupportAssist for Business PCs User's Guide • Latitude 7350 Owner's Manual • APEX Navigator for

Component	Capitalization rule	Examples
		Multicloud Storage: Using Your Service • A webpage title: Identity Management
Chapter (in a Tridion or other book-length publication)	Sentence case	• Configuring alert and event settings • Set up your Latitude 7350
Topic (in a Tridion publication)	Sentence case	• Device credentials and credential profiles • Remove the display assembly
Heading within a chapter or a page	Sentence case	• Set up an OpenManage Enterprise adapter • About this task
Table and figure titles	Sentence case	**Table titles:** • Types of email notifications • Device types and supported features **Figure titles:** • Figure 1. System Parameters page • Figure 20. Installing the display assembly
Table column or row headings (sometimes called table headers)	Sentence case	• Device type or model • Widgets • Assessment factors
Headers repeating at the top of pages in a document (or footers repeating at the bottom).	Often determined automatically by an authoring tool. The text within headers and footers should duplicate that of the content being repeated. For example, if a document title is being duplicated in a footer, it should reflect the capitalization we use for titles.	N/A

Localization considerations for UI content for titles and headings

- When writing UI content for titles or headings for a global audience:
  - Do not hard code fonts.
  - Because word length varies by language, as a general rule leave 30 percent of additional character length to accommodate languages that expand after translation.
  - For languages with glyphs, consider height and width as a design factor.
  - Some languages, such as Arabic and Hebrew, are read from right to left, which means their characters are also displayed from right to left.
  - Chinese, Japanese, and Korean glyphs are monospaced, which means characters are the same width and have equal space between them.

For more, see Locale format standards.

Change notes

Sources:

- TWSG Document components > Headings
- APEX SG Headers and body text
- DDS 2.0 Headings

Change description	**Guides affected (APEX SG, TWSG, DDS, IDS)**
"Localization" replaced "Internationalization"	DDS
Changed topic name from Headings to Titles, headings, and headers	TWSG
Titles, headings, and headers defined	All
Guidance on heading and body text tags: Made generic, removed authoring tool specifics	APEX SG

Steps in a procedure

These guidelines are general best practices for writing steps in a procedure. For CE&T-specific standards for task topics, where step elements such as numbering are controlled by DITA tags, see Guidelines for writing task topics.

Follow these guidelines for multiple-step procedures:

- Limit a procedure to seven to nine numbered steps, and preferably fewer. In web content, try to fit all the steps on the same screen.
- Make each step a complete sentence ending with a period.
- Use consistent sentence structure for all steps: Start each step with an imperative verb phrase. Exception: Where needed, begin the step with a phrase to tell the user where to start, then follow with the imperative.

  Example

  In the Warranty Schedule dialog box, select **Enable Warranty Data Retrieval**.
- When a step includes a phrase that indicates the purpose or a condition of the action, state the purpose or condition before the action.

  Example

  If you do not want to use Active Directory, select **Create a Connection Profile**.
- When including explanatory text, including any description of the results of the step, put the text in a separate paragraph under the step. Use present, not future or past, tense.

  Example

  The Connection Profile is created.

Follow these guidelines for optional steps:

- In a list of steps that contains an options step, add the work *Optional* in parentheses at the end of the step.

  Example

  Step 1. Open the server case.

  Step 2. Pat the server case and tell it you mean no harm. (Optional)

  Step 3. Remove the CPU.

Follow this guideline for single-step procedures:

- Use the same format for single-step procedures but replace the number with a bullet.

Change notes

Source:

- TWSG

Change description	Teams affected (APEX SG, TWSG, DDS, IDS)
No change to guideline, just enhanced with best practices based on an issue ticket.	TWSG

Lists

Lists can be either ordered, unordered, or definition lists. Lists help readers understand information quickly. Do not overuse lists: A series of vertical lists can make your document look like an outline rather than a complete document.

For information about using periods and capitalization in lists, see Periods and Capitalization.

Unordered and ordered lists

- Follow these guidelines when creating unordered and ordered lists:
- Use an unordered list when the sequence of the list items is not important.
- Use an ordered list when the sequence of the list items is important.
- Use a colon at the end of the introductory sentence when the sentence appears immediately before the list.
- Use parallel construction in the text. Begin each list item with the same part of speech, usually a verb or a noun.
- Capitalize the first word of each list item, unless the word is a command or filename, or is another word that always begins with a lowercase letter, such as iDRAC and iSCSI.
- Ensure that the list items are grammatically parallel.

  Incorrect:

  I enjoy:

  - Hiking
  - To swim
  - And reading books

  Correct:

  I enjoy:

  - Hiking

  - Swimming
  - Reading books

- If possible, standardize list items as either complete sentences or sentence fragments.
- If the list items are complete sentences, end the item with a period.
- If the list items are sentence fragments, do not end them with a period unless the introduction to the list is an incomplete sentence and the list items complete the sentence.
- If a list must include both complete sentences and sentence fragments—for example, a list of items (sentence fragments) in which one or more items also includes an explanatory sentence—use end punctuation on every item in the list.
- Ensure that you have at least two items in a list and avoid having more than nine list items.
- Avoid nesting lists beyond two levels.
- Also see Lists in Writing for accessibility.

Definition lists

- Use definition lists to explain terms and concepts.

  Example:

Local Area Network (LAN)	A computer network that interconnects computers within a limited area such as a school or an office facility
Wide Area Network (WAN)	A computer network that interconnects a broad area such as across offices and cities

Introducing a list

Follow these guidelines when introducing lists:

- Include an introductory sentence before a list to explain the purpose of the list. As much as possible, use complete sentences to introduce lists. If you cannot use a complete introductory sentence, ensure that the list items complete the sentence and add periods at the end of the list items.
- Use a colon at the end of an introductory sentence. However, if there is a sentence between the introductory sentence and the list items, use a period to end both the introductory sentence and the intervening sentence.

  Example:

  The following components are Field Replaceable Units (FRUs). They are removed and installed only by Dell-certified service technicians.

  - Intrusion switch
  - System board

In a DITA task topic, the introductory sentence before steps is optional if the task title clearly implies what the procedure is or if you have used the DITA *Steps* tag.

Tables

Follow these guidelines for creating tables:

- Provide clear introductory context for a table, usually by preceding the table with an explanatory body paragraph. Use generic terms to introduce the table and ensure that the table immediately follows its introduction.

  Example:

  The following table shows the CloudBoost appliance dependencies for specific cloud providers.
- Use the phrase the following table or the preceding table to refer to tables within a topic.
- Use tables to present information that users might want to quickly scan and that can be neatly sorted into two or more categories.
- Avoid creating tables with more than four or five columns. Tables with too many columns are difficult to scan and view on mobile devices.
- If a table spans multiple pages, ensure that column headings are repeated on subsequent pages.
- Avoid making the last column of a table a catchall for comments, examples, and descriptions. If possible, separate the information into unique columns.
- If an uncommon abbreviation appears only in a table, spell it out in the table. If an uncommon abbreviation appears first in a table and later in the text, use your best judgment as to whether to use up space in the table or to spell out the term when it first appears in the text.
- Whenever possible, avoid footnotes in tables. Add a short phrase or sentence in parentheses instead of using a footnote.
- If you must use footnotes, use asterisks for a single note and superscripted numbers for multiple notes as reference marks to the footnotes.

In DITA authoring:

- When cross-referencing a table, do not manually enter a table title or number in your text. Doing so increases the risk that the referenced title in the text and the actual title will be mismatched. Also, the numbering is unknown until the output is created.
- Avoid cross-references to tables that are in another topic. When you must create such cross-references in the XML content repository, consider inserting a content reference or creating a

relationship table <reltable>. Create cross-references only to a normal table (<table>) and ensure that the normal table has a <title> element.

See Capitalization for capitalization rules for tables and table elements.

Table titles

Table titles give context and help to orient the reader. Follow these guidelines when creating table titles.

- Ensure that the table title provides a concise, specific, and accurate description of the table content.
- Use sentence-style capitalization.
- Do not use end punctuation in table titles.

Column headings

Follow these guidelines for column headings in tables:

- Ensure that a column heading is specific and identifies the category of all cell-entry items.
- Use the singular for a column heading when each cell in the column contains a single item.
- Use the plural for a column heading when:
  - A single cell in the column contains multiple items, whether in a list format or not.
  - The column heading refers to the number of items in a category.

  Examples:

  Options

  CPUs
- Do not use end punctuation.

Cell text

Follow these guidelines when creating table cell text:

- Order items logically—in numerical or alphabetical order, for example.
- Be concise. Too much text in a cell defeats the purpose of a table.
- Use parallel structure.
- Capitalize the first word in each cell, unless the word is a command or filename, or is another word that always begins with a lowercase letter, such as iDRAC and iSCSI.
- If possible, use either complete sentences or sentence fragments.
  - If you use complete sentences, end them with a period.
  - If you use sentence fragments, do not end them with a period.
  - If text in any one column includes a sentence fragment followed by a complete sentence in the same paragraph, use end punctuation in every cell in the column.

Specification tables

- If relevant specifications are defined in the Dell Technologies Product Specifications, follow those guidelines. [link TBD]
- Otherwise, follow these guidelines when creating specifications tables:
- Spell out numbers one through nine, unless they pertain to measurements or currency.
- Do not include *one* for single items unless the item is in a series.
- Spell out the first number if two numbers are next to each other.

Example:

Component	**Specification**
Video	6-pin connector
Network adapter	RJ45 connector
Drives	one 3.5-inch drive bay; three 5.25-inch drive bays

- Unless spelling out to or through, use an en dash to indicate a range of numbers.
- Use an x to indicate multiplication in a table. Do not use an asterisk.

  Example:

  2 x 10
- If an uncommon abbreviation appears only in a table, spell it out in the table. If an uncommon abbreviation appears first in a table and later in the text, use your best judgment as to whether to use up space in the table to spell out the abbreviation or to spell out the term when it first appears in the text.
- Where a number begins a sentence, spell out the number.

Figures

Follow these guidelines for figures:

- In general authoring, a figure title (caption) is a best practice.

- In DITA authoring, always use a figure title tag when adding a figure to a document.
- In DITA authoring, avoid cross-references to figures that are in another topic. When you must create such cross-references in Tridion, consider inserting a content reference.
- In DITA authoring, do not use figure numbers to refer to figures in text. Doing so increases the risk that the referenced title in the text and the actual title will be mismatched. Also, the numbering is unknown until the output is created. In text, refer to figures using a phrase such as see the following figure or the preceding figure.

Using warnings, cautions, and notes

For how to insert warning, cautions, and general notes in Tridion documents, see the CE&T KB.

Follow these guidelines for using warnings, cautions, and general notes:

- Warnings and cautions must precede, not follow, the content to which they refer.
- Notes can either precede or follow the content to which they refer, depending on the context.
- Always place warnings, cautions, and notes in the order of severity when they appear together. Present warnings first, followed by cautions and then notes.

Warnings

A warning indicates a potential for property damage, personal injury, or death.

Follow these guidelines for using warnings:

- Always place warnings before the content to which they refer.
- Use warnings judiciously. If you overuse warnings, they lose their importance.
- If you must use successive warnings, put them in separate paragraphs.
- If the document does not have the warnings, cautions, and notes legend (for example, a tech sheet), include a section called Warnings that contains the legend.

Cautions

A caution indicates either potential damage to hardware or loss of data and tells the user how to avoid the problem.

Follow these guidelines for using cautions:

- Always place cautions before the content to which they refer.
- Use cautions judiciously. If you overuse cautions, they lose their importance.

- If you must use successive cautions, put them in separate paragraphs.
- If the document does not have the warnings, cautions, and notes legend (for example, a tech sheet), include a section called Cautions that contains the legend.

Notes

A note indicates important information that helps the user make better use of the product or solution. The information is useful to the reader but is not necessary to complete a task.

Follow these guidelines for using notes:

- Use notes judiciously. If you overuse notes, they lose their importance.
- If you must use successive notes, put them in separate paragraphs.
- Where notes relate to a part of a table and where the noted information would distort the table or make the information more difficult to grasp, you can put the information in a footnote immediately following the table. Use an asterisk for one note and superscripted numbers for multiple notes as reference marks to the footnotes.

References to external content

- References to external content such as websites must be accurate and use a consistent style.
- When you create a web reference, it usually has two parts: the text you see, which is the link, and the actual web address, which is hidden. Different authoring tools have various ways to link the visible text with the hidden URL, making it clickable and functional.
- CE&T writers: See the CE&T KB for xref authoring details.
- Because they can often change, keep references to external websites to a minimum, and especially those external to Dell Technologies.
- When referring customers to websites, follow these guidelines:
- For accessibility and consistency with modern standards, visible link text should generally be the human-readable title of the web page.
- Ensure that links in online documentation, whether HTML or PDF, are clickable links.

  Exception: In printed documentation including a URL is your only option for indicating a web destination.
- Keep links to external references at as high a level as possible. Specific pages and addresses change frequently—the web page you cite today might no longer exist after your content is published. When directing customers to the Dell Support site, for example, link to the Support with link text

Dell Support Site and the hidden URL *https://www.dell.com/support* rather than linking to a specific document or product landing page.

Example:

Rewards are issued to your online Dell Rewards Account—available through your Dell.com My Account—typically within 30 business days after your order's ship date.

See the Dell Support Site for more information.

Suggested wording for different types of references: *see*, *go to, from*

- When referring users to a site for information only, use *see*.

  Example:

  For more information about courses offered at Dell Technologies, *see* Dell Technologies Training and Certification.

- When directing users to a site where they perform actions, use *go to.*

  Example:

  To enroll in a Dell Technologies course, go to Dell Technologies Training and Certification and click Catalog Search.

- When instructing users to download a file, use the preposition *from*.

  Example:

  Download the product video *from* the Dell Support Site .

Change notes

Aligned with standard for accessibility for web links, including CE&T Tridion accessibility requirements.

Aligns with guidance in Links topic.

Source:

TWSG

Change description	**Guides affected (APEX SG, TWSG, DDS, IDS)**
Was: Use a URL for link text, including "spell out URL in visible link text" *Changed to*: Visible link text must be human-readable, such as the title of a web page. Reason: TWSG guidance was out of date and in conflict with current accessibility requirements and CE&T KB. For CE&T writers, it causes a Validator error.	TWSG

Trademarks

Follow this guideline for trademarks:

- Do not use trademarks or the trademark symbol in the body of technical content or documentation. This includes the trademarks of others, unless otherwise required. Contact your writing manager for clarification if in doubt.
- In Tridion publications, a standard trademark notice is automatically included in the front matter.

Writing about the UI

If you are writing *about* the UI rather than writing content that goes *into* the UI, follow these guidelines for general standards and the verbs to use for common operations with the mouse or keyboard. For details on standard names of specific UI components, and the standards for UX writers populating those components with content, see the relevant components in the UI components section.

General guidelines

Follow these general usage guidelines when referring to UI components:

- Match the capitalization, spelling, and wording of UI components as they appear in the UI. However, if something is incorrectly or inconsistently represented in the UI, let your product team know about the issue. If there is a spelling error in the UI, use the correct spelling in the documentation.
- Always represent the actionable text appearing in the UI in bold font or its DITA equivalent in your documentation. This guideline applies to wizard titles, window titles, component labels, and any other UI text.

  Incorrect: In the **Modify NVMe target** window, change the current private **IP Role** to **Storage Only**.

  Correct: In the Modify NVMe target window, change the current private IP Role to **Storage Only**.

  Incorrect: Click **OK** to close the **Edit VM** dialog box.

  Correct: Click **OK** to close the Edit VM dialog box.
- Do not tag a generic noun or verb as a UI element.

  Incorrect: Enter your **Password**.

  Correct: Enter your password.
- If a punctuation mark other than a question mark follows a menu item, do not include the punctuation mark when documenting the user interface.

  Incorrect: Right-click **All virtual disks** and select **DR Now**....

  Correct: Right-click **All virtual disks** and select **DR Now**.

Mouse

- Use the following guidelines to describe actions with a mouse:
- Use the verbs *click*, *double-click*, and *right-click* to describe actions that are performed using a mouse. Do not use the preposition *on* after these verbs.

  Correct: Click **OK** to close the Edit VM dialog box.

Correct: Right-click the SDS and select **Exit Maintenance Mode**.

- Use *hover over* instead of *point to* or *mouse over* to refer to the action of briefly resting the mouse pointer on a button, link, or similar element to see a definition or description.

  Correct: Hover over a data point to view the capacity on a specific date.

  Correct: Hovering over each block on the timeline identifies the associated group.

NOTE: To refer to multiple mouse devices, use *mouses*. Do not use *mice*.

Keyboard

- Use the following guidelines to describe actions on a keyboard:
- If a key has a letter on it, use uppercase to describe the key. If a key has a symbol, such as /, +, and —, spell out the name of the key followed by the symbol in parentheses. If the key includes a shortened form of the name, use the shortened form unless it causes confusion.

  Correct: Press the backslash key (\).

  Correct: Press Caps Lock.

  Correct: Enter N.
- In general, use *press* to describe the action of pressing a key. Use *enter* to enter a value in a field by using a key. Do not use *hit, punch, push, or strike*.

  Correct: Press Enter.

  Correct: Enter Y.

  Correct: Press Y to create a profile.
- Do not tag key names.
- To show keys pressed simultaneously, use a plus sign with no spaces.

  Correct: Press Ctrl+Alt+Delete.

  Correct: Press Ctrl+plus sign key (+).
- To show a key sequence (pressing a key, releasing it, and then pressing another key), use a comma followed by a space between the keys.

  Correct: Press Alt, A.
- Do not use an article and the word key with key names unless you are spelling out the name of the key.

  Correct: Press Enter.

Correct: Press the plus sign key (+).

Common UI verbs

- Use the following common verbs to describe how users perform specific actions in a UI:

Clear	Use when referring to the action of removing a check mark from a check box. Do not use *deselect* or *uncheck*. **Correct**: Clear the **Show track changes** check box.
Click	Use with command buttons, dialog boxes, menu buttons, option buttons, tabs, and hyperlinks. Do not use the preposition *on* or *at* after *click*. **Correct**: Click **New**.
Close	Use when referring to closing a window, tab, page, dialog box, or document. **Correct**: Close the **Publish** window.
Drag	Use to describe the action of selecting and moving an object. Do not use *click and drag* or *drag and drop*. The action of dragging also involves dropping the object to another location. **Correct**: Drag the file to the desktop.
Enter	Use when referring to entering text in a field. Do not use *type, input, key, key in, provide, supply, add,* or *put in* when you are referring to entering text in a UI element. **Correct**: Enter the value in the **Default** field.
Open	Use when referring to opening a window, page, dialog box, or document. **Correct**: Open the **Publish** window.
Select	Use when referring to selecting an item from a list or selecting a choice in a check box. Also, use *select* when you are unable to verify the action to be taken. Do not use *choose, tick, put a tick, pick,* or *put a check mark*. *Select* implies the choice of something over something of equal standing. **Correct**: Select the **Remember my password** check box**.**

	Correct: From the Items list, select **Background**.
Tap	Use where referring only to a touch device. Where you are referring to a situation where both touch and mouse devices apply, use *click*. Do not use *click or tap*.

Change notes

Sources:

TWSG and IDD SG 4.0 to restore UI elements content TWSG dropped.

Minor updates for modern standards

UI components—Writing the UI

Both Experience Design Group (EDG) and Dell Digital (DD) have documented extensively the design aspects of the components they use in their respective design system style guides. The USG does not contain design guidance for UI components, but only treats the writing guidelines for them. Where the EDG and DD design system style guides conflicts with the USG, the guidance here takes precedence. The expectation is that EDG and DD are responsible for keeping the writing guidance in their guides consistent with any changes the USG team implements in future.

This section treats guidelines for writing content as part of the UI. For guidance on how to write *about* the UI, see Writing about the UI.

NOTE: Where possible we have included an example of the component and an explanation of its parts and relevant terminology.

About

The About component conveys product branding and highlights key product information.

This component includes only specific types of content such as the product icon or product name, and version and copyright information.

Accordion

An Accordion component displays or hides subsections of content.

Figure 1: Parts of the Accordion component

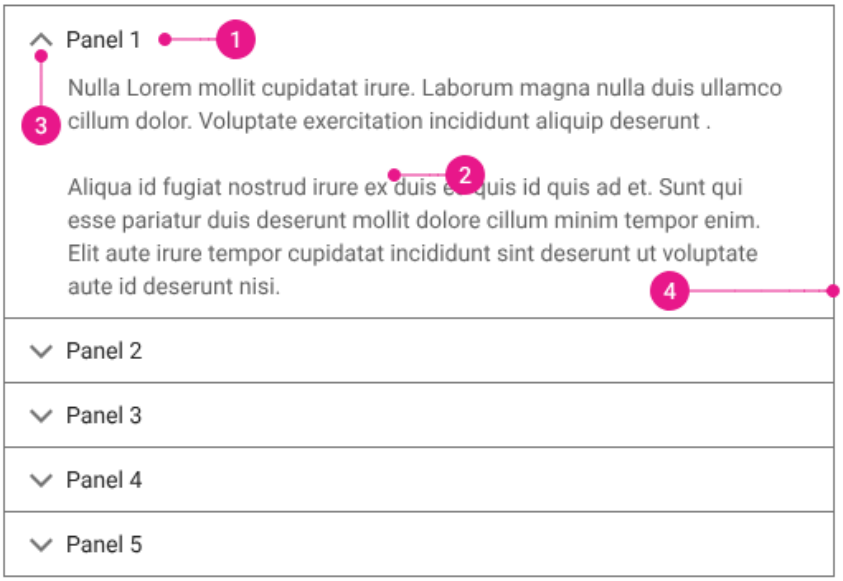


Table 1: Parts of the Accordion component

1	Panel title	Name given to a section of expandable/collapsible content (title case).
2	Body content	Space that contains the main content for each section. Can include one or more paragraphs of text, images, or other components such as a checkbox group.
3	Chevron icon	An interactive and clickable component that triggers the expand and collapse action of the detailed content.
4	Panel	The container that holds a section of expandable and collapsible content.

- Avoid using error messages or other critical information in an Accordion component.
- Panel titles must be concise, descriptive, and inform users what the hidden content contains.
- Avoid using more than a short paragraph under each Panel title.

Related topics

Writing for accessibility

Action menu

An action menu presents users with additional options when there are space constraints within a layout.

Figure 1: Parts of the Action menu component

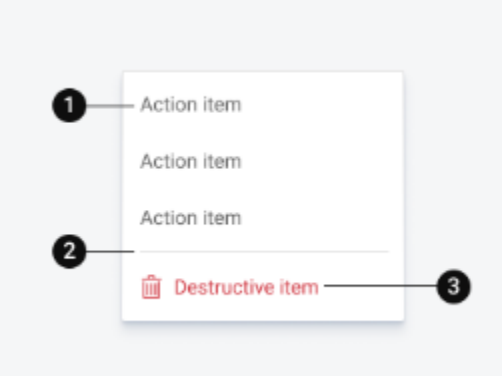


Table 1: Parts of the Action menu component

1	Label	Describes the actions or options the user may select.
2	Divider	Visually separates the actions.
3	Destructive item	
	Trigger	The icon or text that opens the action menu. Not shown above.

- Action menu labels must be clear, concise, and accurately describe what happens when the action is selected. If the same action menu item is available in another place, make sure the label is consistent.
- Ensure that icon-only action items have labels that can be read by a screen reader.
- If using text or a button with text as a trigger, avoid verbs that imply selecting the trigger performs an action. The trigger isn't performing an action. The items within the action menu perform the action.

  Incorrect: Edit

  Correct: More
- Use one- or two-word labels for items within the menu for visual comprehension. Group similar actions together. If a menu item is longer than two words, it likely belongs in a regular navigation menu.

  Incorrect: Edit this item, View more information, Share on Facebook

  Correct: Edit, View, Share

Related topics

Writing for accessibility

Badges

A badge is a visual label or indicator used quickly to convey status or highlight content.

Figure 1: Parts of the Badge component

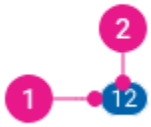


Table 1: Parts of the Badge component

1	Badge container	The size of the container is determined by the numbers displayed in the badge.
2	Counter	Numeric value to display the number of events.

- Do not use a badge to display text. Use a label instead.
- Always use single, double, or triple-digit numerical values.
- For values 999 and over, use 1K and consider being explicit with the actual number on tooltip hover text.

Blockquote

Blockquote refers to an external source which may not already be mentioned and is placed within the reader's flow. A typical use case might include highlighting positive feedback or product reviews from customers. Blockquotes can also help break up large portions of text.

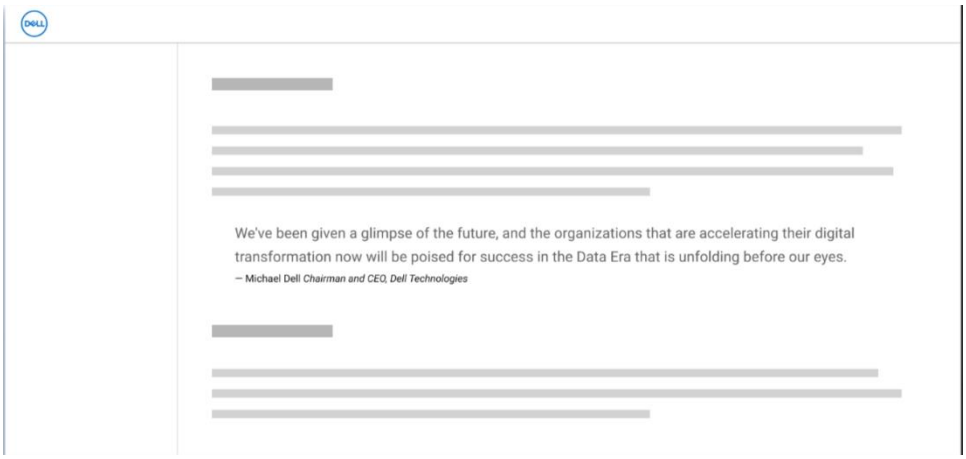


Figure 1: Example of a Blockquote

Don't confuse *blockquote* and *pull quote*. A *blockquote* is a quotation with a citation, designed to be offset from the main text on a page. A *pull quote* is a short excerpt taken from the presented text.

Follow these guidelines for blockquotes:

- Blockquotes are quotations that are longer than 40 words.
- Offset blockquotes from the main text
- Do not include quotation marks
- Make sure the quotation is contextually relevant and accurate
- Do not reformat the text style
- Blockquotes can be left-aligned, center-aligned, or right-aligned, depending on the page layout and design.

Breadcrumbs

Breadcrumbs represent the path the user has taken to arrive at their current location and usually appears at the top of page. Follow these guidelines when writing breadcrumb text:

- The page trail should begin with the highest page in the hierarchy and follow the page order that the user moves through up to the current page.
- Titles in breadcrumbs must reflect the H1 title or heading of the pages to which they correspond. They are always in title case.

Change notes:

Affected style guide	Change
APEX style guide	Would need to shift from sentence case to title case.
IDS	Didn't include truncation section because the text within the breadcrumbs is not truncated. The levels are truncated, and that seems more like design guidance.

Buttons

Each button should have a concise and descriptive label. Try to keep button labels to one or two words, with a maximum of three words or 22 characters.

- Use title case for button copy.

  Incorrect: Submit order

  Correct: Submit Order

- Button copy should reiterate titles or copy in which the action is taken. For example, in confirmation modals prior to deleting information, a common question is Are you sure you want to delete? Buttons to proceed with deletion should reiterate Delete rather than Yes or OK.
- Avoid brand names in button copy.
- Avoid prepositions, articles (a, an, the), and punctuation.
- Do not use all caps for button copy. However, there are occasions where there is no appropriate action text for the button. In these cases, it is acceptable to use OK.

  Incorrect: Okay

  Incorrect: Ok

  Correct: OK

- Use verbs for buttons rather than yes or no. This helps make buttons more user friendly and leaves less room for misinterpretation.

Cards

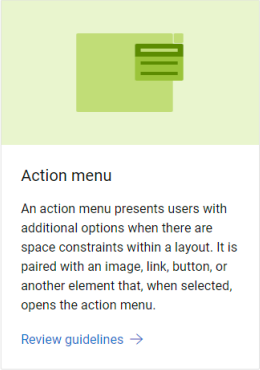
Cards are containers that display concise information about a single subject. They can display featured information, related content, or navigational choices. In groups, cards present collections of similar content.

From a navigational perspective, cards function similarly to links. When used for featured information or related content, they are comparable to a list or a table component. In the latter instances, for example, ecommerce experiences will often include a toggle to switch between a list and card view.

Cards may contain the following types of text:

- Title (required)—write using sentence-case style
- Subtitle (optional)—write using sentence-case style
- Description text for charts, graphs, and other content (optional)—write using sentence-case style
- Text links—write using sentence-case style

Example:



Source: https://www.delldesignsystem.com/components/components-overview/

Related topics:

Cards explained in Dell Design System (DDS)

Cards definition by Nielsen Norman Group

Carousels

A Carousel is a container that enables users to navigate horizontally to view different content placed inside the component.

Figure: Parts of a Carousel component

- No more than 1-2 lines of content.
- Keep your copy concise. Carousel is already a complex component, so if it contains text, such as an announcement or a description, it should be concise. The objective is to keep a small amount of information so that users can easily comprehend the content of all the slides. Do not use the H1 class within the carousel.

Checkboxes

Checkboxes allow a user to select zero, one, some, or all options in a set. Each option is independently selectable, without affecting the states of the other checkbox selections. Checkboxes are often used for confirmation of terms or for opt in/opt out messaging. Keep it straightforward, simple, and clear so that users understand what happens when they check or uncheck a checkbox. A single checkbox is common when a user must confirm or acknowledge something prior to performing an action.

Anatomy

Figure: Anatomy of a checkbox group

Table 1: Parts of the Checkbox component

1	Group label	Name of the group of checkboxes

2	Checkbox	Actionable element
3	Text label	Option name
4	Error message	

General Checkbox guidelines

- Avoid default selections. Preselected choices are considered a deceptive practice for all users. Implement a default unselected state.
- Present all choices and ensure that those choices don't overlap.

  Incorrect:
  Ages 1 to 10
  Ages 10 to 16
  Ages 16 to 20

  Correct:
  Ages 1 to 10
  Ages 11 to 15
  Ages 16 to 20

- Present options in a logical or easily scannable order such as alphabetically or by popularity. Keep in mind that if listing options alphabetically, the order may change when text is localized.

Checkbox text labels

- For group labels, state the category of the grouping.
- Use clear and concise labels so users can easily scan options. The biggest usability issues for checkboxes come from labels that are vague, misleading, or describe options that are difficult for users to understand.
- Make all checkbox labels consistent in length, tense, and meaning.
- Use sentence case with no period.

  Exception: Punctuate confirmation statements like "I accept."

- Avoid wrapping text to a second line.

  Exception: Standalone checkboxes such as "I accept the terms and conditions" may have a sentence or more of text so that the user is informed about what they're agreeing to.

- Use positive language: "I want to," rather than "I don't want to."

  Incorrect: I don't want to receive promotional email

  Correct: I want to receive promotional email

- Where possible, use imperative verbs when writing labels.

Incorrect: I want to receive email promotions.

Correct: Receive email promotions

- Checking a box typically corresponds to opting in, and unchecking a box corresponds to opting out. Your content should reflect that pattern.

Terms and conditions

- When a checkbox requires users to agree to terms or service, use the first person and end punctuation. Provide a link to the what the user is accepting or agreeing to.
  Example: I agree to the terms and conditions.

Accessibility

- For checkbox variants without labels, such as those used within a table, a hidden label is still required for assistive technologies. WCAG 2.1: 1.3.1 Info and Relationships, 2.4.6 Headings and Labels
- All keyboard interactions and ARIA labels must meet accessibility criteria. See WAI-ARIA Checkbox Authoring Practices.

Data grids and tables

Data grids and tables graphically represent tabular data. Data grids and complex tables can be filtered and sorted. The data in data grids can be manipulated, while the data in tables is read-only. Data grids and tables are primarily composed of rows, columns, and a toolbar, but can also have pagination controls and scrollbars. Data grids can have detail panels.

For information about using pagination with data grid and tables, see Pagination.

When there is no data to show in a data grid or table, provide a clear message that communicates why it is empty.

Date and time picker

Date and time pickers should follow internationalization guidelines depending on the intended audience. For more information on globalization requirements, visit the Locale Format Standards on Confluence.

- The component label should clearly and succinctly describe the date or time picker's intended purpose, providing expected formatting when possible.

  Incorrect: Select a departure date

  Incorrect: Departure

  Correct: Departure (mm/dd/yyyy)

- Use sentence case for labels, helper text, and placeholder text.

  Incorrect: Choose an Appointment Time

  Correct: Appointment time

- When using a 12-hour time format, include the a.m. or p.m. abbreviations to specify morning or afternoon. Abbreviations are lowercase and include periods.
- Do not rely on placeholder text to show formatting. A mask can be shown within the input, but the expected format should remain in the label where it is always referenceable.
- Helper text can be used to show formatting, such as Format: dd/mm/yyyy. However, it is not preferred as opening the calendar will hide the format from view. Showing examples of a valid date in the helper text or providing contextual information are preferred.

Change notes:

Affected style guide	Change
ISG	Date format in helper text (listed in anatomy section).

Drawer [TBD]

Dropdown menus

Every dropdown should have a label to identify and describe its purpose, providing guidance and assuring readability and accessibility.

- Label text should be left-aligned (or right-aligned for right-to-left languages) with the input.

  Incorrect: Select Your Locale
  Correct: Locale

- Do not use decorative images or icons in labels.
- Write clear and succinct label text in sentence case.
- Use sentence case for dropdown menu items.

  Incorrect: Appointment Time
  Correct: Appointment time

- If possible, use one-word titles for groups of similar items within the dropdown.

  Incorrect: Layout controls
  Correct: Layout

- Avoid multiple lines of text in a dropdown. If the text is too long for one line, add an ellipsis (…) for overflow content, and accompany with a tooltip to show the full string of text.
- The minimum width of the menu list is the width of the input field. The lists width is adaptive to its content and may exceed the input field's width.

Empty state messages

Empty states engage users who encounter an unfilled container or blank page. Empty state messaging is an opportunity to provide users with additional information, whether it's a suggestion to take immediate action or to try again later. In any case, explaining why a user is seeing an empty state can alleviate confusion and help them understand what to do next.

Empty states can use call-to-action buttons when the next step is obvious to the user. Limit the number of buttons to provide a clear course of action. For example, if the empty state is illustrating that there are no search results available, the button can provide a way to return or try again. Or if the component is an interactive container, an empty state button can prompt the user to add content.

Four types of frequently encountered empty states include:

First use: occurs with a new product or service when there is still nothing to show, such as an empty favorites list or an empty sent messages folder. First use products or applications will show an empty state until the user creates or configures the screen. This includes dashboard views and other areas where users are encouraged to personalize their view.

User cleared: occurs when users complete actions such as clearing their inbox or task list, and the result is an empty screen. As a direct result of user action, an empty state may not need to alert users to do anything more, but simply inform users that they've completed their tasks with a success message.

No results: occurs when there are no results to show. This can happen if a user performs a search and the query is empty, or from an incorrect search due to misspellings, or from the use of filters.

No data: occurs when a user finds a screen before there is information available to populate it. Examples include tables and data visualizations, where information may be reset on a monthly or annual basis.

Error messages [TBD]

File input

A file input is an interactive field that allows users to select files. File inputs are commonly used in form patterns to attach supporting documentation, such as a PDF of a purchase agreement or a spreadsheet of business expenses.

- Clearly spell out accepted file types, file size, and quantity in the instructions. If users are shown an error, be specific on what caused the error and how to fix it.

  Incorrect: Invalid file
  Correct: This file exceeds the 5 MB size limit. Select a smaller file to continue.
- In general, files are not uploaded until after a form is submitted. Communicate file upload status accurately.

Footnote

Located at the bottom of a page, footnotes provide additional information or a source for content in the main body of a page.

Footnotes have 3 elements to attribute sources or provide additional information: a numerical citation to identify the page content reference, footnote text to identify source or information, and a back-to-citation link to navigate back to original page text as shown.

Refer to the Chicago Manual of Style for specific content instructions for various types of footnotes.

Global alerts

Global alerts communicate an application-level message and its severity to the user. They are located at the top of the product, above the masthead. Their purpose is to provide global alerting in the full context of the software application.

Use global alerts to inform the user of a major event that happened to the software application, or to inform the user of something extremely important within the software application.

Components of a global alert

- **Carousel** *(optional)*: For multiple alerts
- **Icon**: Alerts have icons related to their severity
- **Message**: Short description of the current event
- **Link** *(optional)*: A link used for navigation, may redirect to a solution or related topic
- **Button icon** *(optional)*: Will display the sort of actions that can be done from the alert
- **Close button**: Dismisses the alert

Types

Alert types convey the severity of the message to the user. This may vary between products but must be consistent per product.

Follow these guidelines for the main types of alert usages:

- An information alert is a message that is beneficial to the user but does not require their immediate attention.
- A warning alert, whether major or minor, conveys a message to the user that they may be in danger of data loss or destruction if they do not act.
- A critical alert communicates that data loss or destruction is imminent if the user does not act.

Group title

Group titles are used to group the related menu items under a heading.

- If possible, use one-word titles for groups of similar items within the same menu.

Incorrect: Layout controls
Correct: Layout

- Use sentence case for group titles if they are longer than one word.

Headings and body text

Table: Heading guidance

Item	HTML code	Purpose	Syntax	Mood	Case	Recommended length
Header 1	H1	Page heading	Noun phrase	N/A	Title	15 characters (one line)
Header 2	H2	Section, modal, popover, right drawer header	Noun phrase	N/A	Sentence	15 characters (one line)
Header 3	H3	Subsection	Noun phrase	N/A	Sentence	15 characters (one line)
Header 4	H4	Not recommended	Noun phrase	N/A	Sentence	15 characters (one line)
Header 5	H5	Not recommended	Noun phrase	N/A	Sentence	15 characters (one line)
Header 6	H6	Not recommended	Noun phrase	N/A	Sentence	15 characters (one line)
Paragraph or body text	P	For short instructions directly in the Console	Sentences with full punctuation and grammar	Imperative	Sentence	50 characters (2 sentences)

See Titles, headings, and headers.

Titles and headings in UI components

For details on titles, headings, and headers as document components, see Titles, headings, and headers. For capitalization rules, see Capitalization.

Localization considerations for UI content for titles and headings

When writing UI content for titles or headings for a global audience:

- Don't hard code fonts.
- Because word length varies by language, as a general rule leave 30 percent of additional character length to accommodate languages that expand after translation.
- For languages with glyphs, consider height and width as a design factor.
- Some languages, such as Arabic and Hebrew, are read from right to left, which means their characters are also displayed from right to left.
- Chinese, Japanese, and Korean glyphs are monospaced, which means characters are the same width and have equal space between them.

See Locale format guidelines.

Helper text

Helper text is instructional text that helps the user fill out the relevant field by providing field explanation or localization assistance. Keep the content concise in helping users prevent errors. Helper text appears below the text field.

- Use when a short explanation of a form-related text input field's purpose is needed.
- One short, complete sentence with full punctuation and grammar.
- Use the indicative mood and try to keep under 50 characters.

Inline alerts

Inline alerts are informational banners that communicate a message with a severity and grab users' attention. Alerts are often triggered by the user's interaction and can sometimes be dismissed. Inline alerts should occur either in-line or right next to the relevant content to which it is referring, or alternatively as close as possible to the user's action that caused it.

Types

Alert types convey the severity of the message to the user. This may vary between products but must be consistent per product.

- An information alert is a message that is beneficial to the user but does not require their immediate attention.
- A success alert communicates that a process has completed without error.
- A warning alert, whether major or minor, conveys a message to the user that they may be in danger of data loss or destruction if they do not act.
- A critical alert communicates that data loss or destruction is imminent if the user does not act.

Instructional or directional messaging

Instructional text provides easy to follow instructions which use simple language and provide information on what to do in chronological order. This can also include a call-out of required fields. Instructional or directional messaging is placed under the page title/header if related to instructions for the entire page, or under a sub-title/header, if related to a instructions for a specific section of the page.

- Use sentence case.
- Be as brief, yet helpful, as possible.
- The aim is to deliver clear and succinct instructions rather than descriptive text.
- Use imperative verbs, like 'get,' 'take,' and 'move.' (verbs that instruct another person to do something).

Examples:

Fill out the contact form below.

Select the type of configuration for this appliance.

Links

Follow these guidelines for using links:

- Link text should describe the page or experience the user is navigated toward.
- Do not replace the link text with a URL or use ambiguous phrases such as click here or learn more.

  Incorrect: https://wcag.com/

  Incorrect: Learn more

  Correct: Visit WCAG
- Link text length is less important than linking a good description. Be concise while accurately describing the referenced page or document.

  Incorrect: Browse Alienware and start gaming!

  Correct: Browse Alienware
- Use sentence case for both standalone and inline links. Only capitalize the first letter for every word for proper nouns, document titles, or product names.

  Incorrect: Visit Our Homepage to start gaming.

  Correct: Visit our homepage to start gaming.
- If the link opens a PDF, another window, or other form of media, precede the link with the icon that represents the media format. It is not necessary to write warnings in the link text.

  Incorrect: Download How to access VPN.pdf for troubleshooting connection issues.

  Correct: Download (icon) How to access VPN.pdf for troubleshooting connection issues.
- If a link comes at the end of a sentence or before a comma, do not include punctuation as part of the link. If possible, rewrite the sentence so the URL is not at the end of the sentence.

  Incorrect: For more information on ARIA labels, visit WCAG 2.1.

  Correct: Visit WCAG 2.1 for more information on ARIA labels.
- Ensure that URLs used in online documentation are clickable links. In printed documentation, however, including a URL is required to indicate a web destination.
- In printed documentation where URLs are visible, keep links to external references at as high a level as possible. Specific pages and addresses may change frequently. Always include the protocol, http: or https:, forward slashes, and the www in your links, except in printed documentation.

  Example:

  Use *https://www.dell.com/support* rather than linking to a specific document or landing page.

- Dell.com, DellTechnologies.com are the names of Dell's various business units and are thus capitalized. Where the domain name is being used as a full URL, however, lowercase is appropriate.

  Example:

  See the Dell Support site *https://www.dell.com/support* for more information.

Suggested wording

- When referring users to a site for information only, use see.
- When directing users to a site where they will perform actions, use go to or visit.

Lists

Lists are used to organize a group of related text elements. Lists and tables are not used for the same purpose. Tables display complex groups of information for the purpose of reference, comparison, or choice. Lists present a group of related information in a scannable format.

- Use bulleted lists when the order of the items doesn't matter.
- Use numbered lists when item order does matter, such as the steps in a process.
- End items with a period only when using complete sentences.
- Single words and partial sentences omit punctuation at the end.
- Construct lists using parallel syntax:
- Each item should respond to or continue the introductory clause in the same way.
- Lists should be composed of all sentences or all fragments.
- If one list item begins with a verb, all items in the list should begin with a verb.
- List items should be approximately the same length.

Loading indicator [TBD]

Message bar

Message bars are nonmodal dialogs that are displayed either at the top of the page or contextually within a task flow. There are two types of message bars, and either can be used for critical system alerts or passive feedback.

Global message bars display nonmodal messages that inform users of updates or changes to system status.

Contextual message bars are most often used in task flows and forms to provide users with additional context or information about a task.

Navigation

- Menus used for site or application wayfinding. Standards apply to all global navigation styles, including masthead and side navigation.
- Try to keep navigation link labels short enough to avoid text wrapping. Menu items must be short enough to scan, but long enough to be clear. Avoid ambiguous or lengthy words or phrases.
- Keep all labels similar in length, context, and type. If using nouns for title pages and links, use nouns in the navigation. If using verbs, use verbs for all link titles and pages.
- Tell users exactly where they are going and what they can expect.
- Establish an information architecture with a properly defined content hierarchy.
- Use icons for primary levels, but not for secondary or tertiary levels.
- Match page titles to navigation menu labels for consistency. For example, if the navigation menu label is *Roles and Permissions*, the title (H1) of the page should be identical.
- Use title case in navigation menus. Note that this rule does not apply to standalone or embedded links, which are sentence case.

  Incorrect: Site management
  Correct: Site Management

Change notes:

Affected guide	Change
DDS 2.0	Update navigation labels to title case.

Notifications, errors, and alert messages

There are four overarching guidelines for writing notifications, errors, and alert messages.

- Write in the active voice as often as possible.
- Write in sentence case.
- Be specific and concise.
- Provide logical next steps, when applicable.
- Titles are optional for error and alert messages. In some cases, a title may help draw attention to the message. In cases of very short errors and alerts, a title may be redundant. Don't use titles for field validation errors.
- Titles don't have to be complete sentences, but they do need to be meaningful phrases that our users will immediately understand. Don't punctuate the title unless it is a complete sentence.
- Avoid including the error code number or other technical terms in error titles. If you must include a code, include it in the error message's body copy.

  Incorrect: Error 500

  Correct: We're experiencing server downtime.
- Write in grammatically correct sentences and phrases.

  Incorrect: 56 standard configurations added to account

  Correct: You successfully added 56 standard configurations to your account.
- Avoid writing lengthy passages of text. Try to limit the body copy to 1–3 sentences.
- When you have multiple messages to state in the body of an alert, consider using a bullet list.
- Describe specifically what happened or what will happen.

  Incorrect: Something went wrong.

  Correct: We're experiencing server downtime.
- Include specific information relevant to the message, such as time or a specific error code, when applicable.

  Correct: Our site will undergo planned maintenance on November 12, 2024, from 6:00 PM CST until November 13, 2024, at 12:00 PM CST.

  Correct: Please contact your account representative and refer to the error code #2048693.
- Provide specific, actionable next steps and solutions, when applicable.

Correct: Try reloading the page. If you’re still experiencing issues, call 1-800-663-4059 or chat with an agent.

Notifications

A notification shows users contextual, timely, and noncritical feedback and messages. Notifications provide information that may or may not require the user to take action.

- Use direct, simple language.
- Do not use apologetic terms such as "Sorry", "Please" or "May". Be polite and diplomatic, but these words are unnecessary and imply that the action expected from the user is optional.
- Do not use colloquialisms, idioms, or jargon.
- Aim for fewer than 20 words.
- Minimize line wraps.
- Use complete sentences and punctuation.
- Use sentence case.
- Use present tense.
- Use active voice.
- Titles don't have to be complete sentences, but they do need to be meaningful phrases that our users will immediately understand. Don't punctuate the title unless it is a complete sentence.

Pagination

Use the following labels with pagination controls, where *x* is replaced with the current page, *y* is replaced with the total number of pages, *z* is replaced with a page count, *z* inside square brackets represents text input, and *z* inside curly brackets represents a select box:

<< First
< Previous
Page [x] of y
> Next
>> Last

Show: {z} per page
{z} Items per page
{z} 1-z

Popovers

A popover is a container that floats over page content after pressing a trigger element. It contains supplemental content related to its trigger, and can be customized to include text, images, and interactions. Popovers are opened with a click or tap (not on hover).

- Required elements for a popover include:

  Title

  Body content (see below)

  Close X button
- Popover content should be brief. A popover should contain no more than two paragraphs of text, or one image and one paragraph (for example, a product image with a review snippet).
- A popover should contain no more than two links in its content. Interaction with these links should be optional. If interaction with such content is required to proceed, then use a modal instead of a popover.
- To close a popover, select the X button within it, or anywhere outside of it.
- Use popovers to convey detailed information about how to complete a task.
- Use popovers to create contextual help with a link that triggers it placed at a specific point on the UI (User Interface).
- Use popovers or tooltips to provide conceptual or reference content such as “Learn more” content. If there is too much content for a popover, consider delivering the content outside the UI within a document.
- Popovers should not contain task-essential information.
- Content should be written in sentence case.

See Tooltips, Signposts

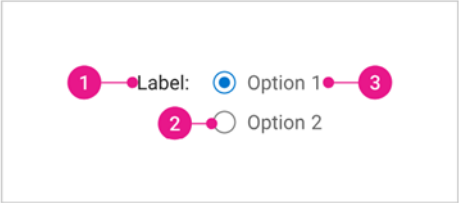
Product stack [TBD]

Progress bar or progress indicator [TBD]

Progress tracker [TBD]

Radio button

Radio buttons require users to make one selection from a group of options. Because the user can select only one option, radio buttons are used to present mutually exclusive choices.



Callout	Item name	Description
1	Label Text	Appears to the left (or above) radio button group. It is a short description of the radio button group.
2	Radio Button	Indicates the current state. You can select only one at a time.
3	Option Text	Appears to the right of each individual radio button. It describes the selectable options.

General guidance for label text

- Make labels short, scannable, and concise.
- Avoid labels that wrap to a second line. These may provide a poor user experience.

- Use title case for group labels.

General guidance for option text

- Use clear and concise descriptions so users can easily scan options. The biggest usability issues for radio buttons come from descriptions that are vague, misleading, or that are difficult for users to understand.
- Present options in a logical or easily scannable order (e.g. alphabetically or by popularity). Keep in mind that if listing options alphabetically, the order will change when text is localized.
- Present all options, and make sure that those options don't overlap.

  Correct:
  Ages 1 to 10
  Ages 11 to 15
  Ages 16 to 20

  Incorrect:
  Ages 1 to 10
  Ages 10 to 16
  Ages 16 to 20

- Use horizontal inline radio buttons sparingly.
- Use a positive tone, signaling affirmation, instead of negation to avoid confusing users.

  Correct: "I want to receive promotional email"
  Incorrect: "I don't want to receive promotional email."

- Avoid punctuating radio button descriptions. An exception is if the description is a complete sentence.
- Do not pre-select or have a default item selected for your users.

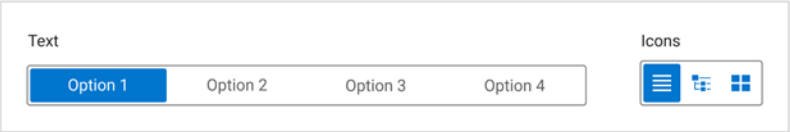
Other

Helper text is short instructional text that helps the user fill out the relevant input by providing an explanation or localization assistance. Keep the content concise in helping users prevent errors. Helper text appears below the radio button group.

The messaging text for form validation errors appears below both the radio button group and the helper text.

Segmented button

A segmented button is a selection pattern configured to switch between alternative views of related content. This pattern only allows for a single option to be selected at a time and only controls the viewing options for content within the same space.



Although a segmented button may look or behave like other components used for selection, such as toggle switches or radio buttons, they should not be used interchangeably.

When an option is selected, it immediately affects an object, state, or view.

Option Text

- Provide two to five options only.
- The first option is selected by default.
- Only one option may be selected at a time.
- Option text (per segment) should be three words or less.
- Use nouns or noun phrases that succinctly describe the option.
- Keep options related to a single topic or category.
- Use either all text or all icons within a single grouping of options, but do not mix the two types.
- Option text (per segment) should not wrap to multiple lines.
- Use title case.

Signposts

Signposts are displayed in a popover dialog box and contain contextual help or information. Signposts can be used when you want to show a small amount of contextual help without taking the user out of the current context. Use sparingly as a supplemental element and not as a primary method of adding detail.

Clicking the trigger, often an (i) icon, opens the signpost. It remains visible until the user clicks the close icon or clicks anywhere outside of the dialog box to dismiss it. To keep the interface uncluttered, only

one signpost is displayed at a time. When a dialog is visible, clicking an icon to open another one automatically dismisses the previous dialog box.

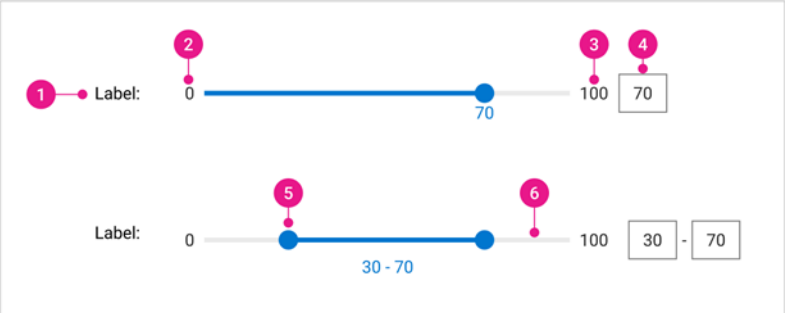
Consider a signpost in the following scenarios:

- When the amount of content won't fit in a tooltip.
- When you want to include a header, an image, or text/image links in the content.
- When the information presented needs to stay in view until the user interacts with another element.
- Content for signposts should be written in sentence case.

See also: Popovers, Tooltips

Slider

A slider allows for the selection of a single value or range of values available by moving a handle along a track.



1	Label text	Describes what kind of value can be selected from the slider.
2	Minimum value	The minimum value that can be selected. Appears to the left.
3	Maximum value	The maximum value that can be selected. Appears to the right of the slider.
4	Editable numerical values	Input to enter exact values.
5	Handle	An indicator that can be moved on the track within the slider range to specify a selected value.
6	Track	Shows a user's available minimum and maximum values on the range to select from.

Label

- Use title case.
- Should be short, scannable, concise.
- Avoid labels that wrap to a second line. These may provide a poor user experience.
- Use one or two words, preferably nouns, that describe the functionality it controls.

Values

- A slider can represent actual values (ex. 0-100) or relative values (ex. low-high).
- Include units of measurement (ex. 48 pixels) to relative values, when possible.

Success messages

Also known as toasts, success messages confirm that an action has completed successfully without requiring user interaction or acknowledgement.

Title

- A title is optional, depending on the component. Avoid using 'Success!' or 'successfully' in a title.
- Include an informative, scannable title. Try and imagine people trying to understand what's happening by reading the title on its own.
- Limit titles to three to four words where possible, excluding "an," "a," or "the." The character count depends on the component chosen.
- Write in sentence case and no use of periods.
- Avoid using exclamations! We don't want to be overly enthusiastic about everything!

Body

- Include the reason for the success - confirm what action someone has taken or what task has been completed. If someone has created something give them an opportunity to view it.
- Avoid repeating content from the title.
- Keep messages to 1 to 2 sentences. Use a few words of praise followed by one or two sentences of informative insight.
- Avoid putting technical information in the message or having people look in another location. If it can't be avoided, use a "Learn more" link.

- It’s important to show possibility once someone has achieved something. Tell people the result of an action.

  Example
  Support ticket created
  The details have been sent to your email and our support team will be in touch with you soon.

Toggle switch

A toggle switch prompts users to choose between two mutually exclusive states. It’s commonly used for changing the state of system functionalities or preferences within an application.

1	Label text	Placed off to the left of the toggle switch, the label provides context for what is being turned on or off.
2	Control	Composed of a thumb that moves along a track to toggle the switch off or on.
3	State text	Placed to the right of the toggle switch, state text describes the current state of the toggle switch.

Label

- Should be short, scannable, concise.
- Avoid labels that wrap to a second line. These may provide a poor user experience.
- Use one or two words, preferably nouns, that describe the functionality it controls.
- The label does not change when the switch is toggled.
- Should not be neutral or ambiguous.
- Avoid unfamiliar terms or asking questions.
- Use title case.

State

- The state text changes when the control changes position.
- Only use mutually exclusive states (states that cannot occur simultaneously):

Incorrect:
Monday | Tuesday
List View | Map View

Correct:
On | Off (default)
Yes | No
Enabled | Disabled

Tabs

- Use sentence case (capitalize only the first word) unless referring to a proper noun.
- Do not punctuate tab labels.
- Write short tab labels and use plain language to accurately describe the content associated with each tab. Try to keep the label text to one or two words. If you need longer labels, it may be a sign that the categories are too complicated for a tab control.
- The character length of a label will affect the width of the tab, and potentially cause other tabs to truncate into an overflow or More menu.
- Ensure each tab's content is connected or related to the other tab views.
- Avoid cross-linking content between tabs.

Change note:

Affected Guide	Change
IDS	Update tab labels to sentence case.

Tags

- Write tag labels in sentence case.
  Incorrect: Storage Admin
  Correct: Storage admin
- Don’t include punctuation in tag text other than a hyphen if one is necessary.
- Tag text should clearly explain the topic or purpose of the tag in one or two words.

- Tags are often used to call out unique keywords that specify and summarize content. Using unique, relevant terms as tags can strengthen a page's search visibility.

Change note:

Affected Guide	Change
Possibly IDS	I didn't see any explicit rules on casing, but all their visual assets use title case for tags (if there is more than one word in the label). I strongly suggest not using title case, as tags are not always interactive and are visually similar to buttons.

Text box

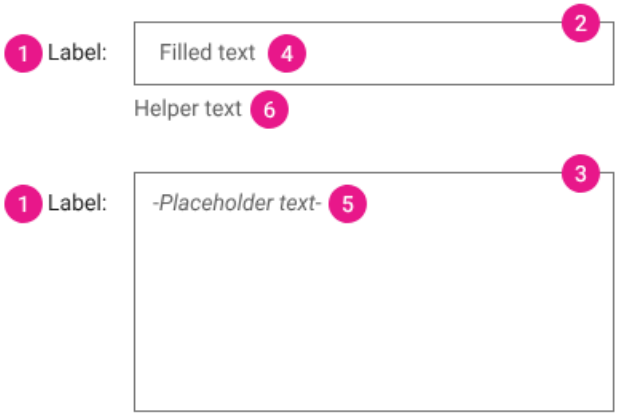
Text boxes allow users to insert custom values in forms. Text boxes allow users to enter or modify free-form text within an application or website. Examples include usernames, passwords, descriptions, URLs, email addresses, street addresses, and plain text searches.

There are two types of text boxes:

Text input to enter limited information.

Text area input for information larger than one sentence.

The following are the parts of a text box:



1	Label	Describes the purpose of the text box.
2	Text input	Users can enter alphanumeric text into a single-line box.
3	Text area	Users can enter alphanumeric text into a multi-line box.

4	Filled text	Alphanumeric text entered into the box.
5	Placeholder text (optional)	Offers contextual guidance. This should only be used when the text is not essential to the user as they type in the box.
6	Helper text (optional)	Provides optional helper text beneath the text box to guide users on formatting such as date formats, minimum or maximum number of characters allowed, or to explain how the provided information will be used.

Use the following guidelines for text boxes:

- Ensure that the label is clear, descriptive, and not more than five words.
- Use sentence case capitalization for labels.
- Ensure that the text box is neither too small nor too large for the expected text.

Tooltips

Tooltips are containers that temporarily display a short, contextual text. They are activated when a user hovers over an icon or other trigger. Tooltips are used to display secondary or additional information of the triggering element. Tooltips can be a source of additional context in form fields.

The guidelines are:

- Do not use tooltips to display error or status messages, long passages of text, images, or interactive content.
- Avoid adding essential information in tooltips.
- Use sentence case.

See also: Popovers, Signposts

View More and View Less

View More and View Less components reveal and hide content. When a user selects the text label or icon, the component expands or collapses vertically to reveal or hide content.

The content may stop mid-sentence, mid-paragraph, or mid-list to save space. The continuation of the content is often indicated by an ellipsis (…) or block arrow, combined with phrases like View More or View Less.

- Use title case for these labels and boldface them.

Related topics

Accordion

Minimalism

Introduction to minimalism

Dell Technologies encourages the use of minimalism principles in its content strategy.

Minimalism principles

- Writing based on minimalism principles is:
- Action-oriented
- Succinct
- Directed toward a well-defined audience

Minimalism benefits

The benefits of writing based on minimalism principles include:

- Better readability on a range of devices
- Lower translation and printing costs
- Easier reuse
- Better searchability
- Users getting their tasks done more efficiently

Minimalism guidelines

Apply the following minimalism guidelines to your writing:

- Know your audience. See Adjust your approach to your audience.

- Do not explain the obvious.
- Write task-oriented topics that focus on user goals and not on product functionality.
- In a task-based approach, provide the reader with task-based topic titles such as Add and remove the system board. In contrast, in a feature-based approach, the add and remove task instructions might be buried within a section titled, *Taking care of your system*, and users might find it difficult to find the information they are looking for.
- Use the active voice rather than the passive voice as much as possible. Sentences written in the passive voice tend to be longer.
- Avoid glue text, such as This section describes… With a good heading, glue text is redundant.
- Write simply and clearly. Remove words that add no value; words or phrases that are long, ambiguous, or convoluted; and content that is not required.
- Avoid nominalization, that is, avoid using nouns instead of verbs, adjectives, or other parts of speech.

  Examples:

  Use *change* instead of *make a change*. Use *search* instead of *perform a search*.
- Provide appropriate information in the right place so that users can easily find and understand the information.
- Ensure that you add troubleshooting content to your documentation. Users tend to look at documentation when they run into a problem.
- Provide supporting information in the appropriate format, such as unordered lists, tables, and notes.
- Reuse information according to best practices and as recommended by information architects.

Examples of minimalist language

Instead of ...	Use ...
add an additional	add
before you begin installing	before you install
combine together	combine
create a new folder	create a folder
critically important	important
due to the fact that	due to

during the course of	during
each individual	each or individual
end result	result
for the purpose of	to or for (depending on the context)
in order to	to
in the event that	if, when
join together	join
make a change to	change
proceed further	proceed
reason why	reason
sequential order	in order, in sequence
shorter/longer in length	shorter, longer
small/large in size	small, large
square/round/rectangular in shape	square, round, rectangular
still remains	remains
sufficient enough	sufficient or enough
sum total	sum or total
type in	type
utilize	use
very important	important
whether or not	whether

Adjust your approach to your audience

A keen understanding of your audience is critical when you are developing content using the tenets of minimalism. Is the user a novice, an advanced beginner, a competent performer, a proficient user, or an expert? Are you writing for the system administrator in charge of a large network, for the gamer who is concerned with tweaking the maximum speed of a single system, or for the small business employee who needs to get the job done? Here are some ways to categorize your user and some considerations to bear in mind when assessing the user.

Novice:

Wants to get started quickly

Wants to get comfortable with new skills

Has little time for learning

Needs some immediate successes

Prefers to start with something familiar, although prior knowledge about the new skill is only theoretical

Advanced beginner:

Wants to be able to perform new tasks as the need arises

Is willing to learn—a little

Is in the beginning stage of practical knowledge and experience

Typifies the level that is achieved by most designers and communicators Competent performer:

Needs to solve problems quickly

Focuses on troubleshooting—needs to identify, diagnose, and solve problems

Organizes and plans

Is willing to break the rules

Proficient user:

Needs to work more effectively

Is ready to learn more concepts

Understands the underlying processes

Performs more advanced tasks

Expert:

Has increased efficiency

Understands results

Needs the complete story, not isolated facts

Topic-based authoring (CE&T)

Introduction to topic-based authoring

Audience: Content Engineering writers using DITA for topic-based authoring in the current Dell CCMS (Component Content Management System) or writers using other topic-based structured authoring tools.

This topic describes writing guidelines for key elements in structured authoring.

For authoring tool technical details, see the CE&T KB.

For information on DITA standards, see OASIS Darwin Information Typing Architecture (DITA) TC.

About DITA

The Darwin Information Typing Architecture (DITA) is a standard that helps authors create topic-based content using standard tags and content components. The standard, which is managed by the Organization for the Advancement of Structured Information Standards (OASIS) DITA Technical Committee, is online here OASIS Darwin Information Typing Architecture (DITA) TC.

Generally, refer to the Content Engineering and Translation Knowledgebase for Dell-specific authoring instructions to create and manage publications. If you are interested in knowing more about a DITA tag, you can search the standard by tag to find the explanation of the tag's purpose.

Writing topic titles and headings

In DITA, "topic title" is the term for a chapter (container) topic title as well as a topic title.

In DITA as in general usage, a heading flags a section of text and calls attention to the organization and content of a topic. Headings provide important signposts for the user. Headings within a topic may be applied with DITA tags such as *Procedure* or *sectiontitle*, but structurally, they are still headings.

The following guidelines apply to titles and headings for all topic types. For guidance specific to concept, reference, and task topic titles and headings, see Task topics, Concept topics, and Reference topics.

Topic titles and headings must be specific, providing a clear, concise description of the content.

Each topic title must be unique within a publication. When you write concept, reference, and task topic titles, ensure that the titles do not repeat the title of an existing, related topic.

Because a topic may be found out of context, as in a search or if reused in another publication, do not use titles that assume context, such as “Overview.”

Incorrect: Overview

Correct: Unisphere overview

Incorrect: Introduction

Correct: Introduction to Unisphere

For concept and reference topics, avoid writing pseudo-task titles that start with verbs such as Understanding, Learning, or Using. Pseudo-task headings can mislead users because the wording suggests that the topic contains task-based information, when it actually contains conceptual or reference information.

Incorrect: Understanding the file system

Correct: File system overview

Incorrect: Learning about the OneFS operating system

Correct: Introduction to the OneFS operating system

Gerunds are OK in titles for chapter **container** topics introducing task topics whose titles are imperatives. For example:

Installing the X solution (topic type: container/bridge/umbrella concept, title phrase type: gerund)—chapter title

Install the X software package (topic type: task, title phrase type: imperative)-task topic grouped with others inside a chapter

Install hardware component Y (topic type: task, title phrase type: imperative)-task topic grouped with others inside a chapter

Do not write topic titles and headings in the form of a question. The type of phrase that you use in a topic title or heading depends on the topic type, as described in the following table.

In general, except for a concept topic that introduces a set of related but mutually exclusive task topics, use singular nouns in headings; however, if the topic describes a plural entity, use the plural form of the noun. See the following table for examples.

Standards for titles for DITA topic types

Topic type	Phrase type	Examples
Concept topic that provides overview, introductory, or descriptive information	Noun phrase	Network management NDMP overview Software module licensing

Topic type	Phrase type	Examples
Concept topic that introduces (or contains) a set of related but mutually exclusive task topics (and, if applicable, any concept or reference topics that support that set of tasks)	Gerund, present participle (-*ing*) verb phrase with a plural noun (or, if applicable, a singular noun)	Creating quotas Managing quotas Activating module licenses Installing the update package
Reference topic	Noun phrase	Internal network settings NIC and LNI aggregation options Quota report components
Task topic	Imperative verb phrase with a singular noun (or, if applicable, a plural noun)	Create an accounting quota Modify a quota Unconfigure a module license Connect the power cables

Short descriptions

Short descriptions are required for Content Engineering content that is developed in DITA, except in cases where the title alone fully conveys what the topic is about or where making the topic findable is not important, as with the standard “Notes, cautions, and warnings” topic in most guides.

The short description is like an essay’s thesis statement. It must be able to stand alone at the start of a topic, and yet the topic itself must not be dependent on it. The short description must not, for example, be the lead-in sentence to the rest of the topic; instead, it must state concisely and clearly what the topic accomplishes.

Well-written short descriptions have benefits for the customer and for you as a writer.

For the customer, a good short description:

Speeds the delivery of correct content to customers through their use in search engine optimization (SEO) or as hoverable tooltips

Helps customers and other writers decide whether a topic has the information that they need

For the writer, a good short description:

Helps you focus on the intent of the topic and convey the information you want to communicate

Optimizes reuse by enabling writers to quickly determine whether the topic is usable within their deliverable

Short descriptions should not start with glue text such as “This topic describes…”.

Task topic short descriptions

A good task topic short description does not simply repeat the title of the task but answers the following questions:

What are the benefits of the task? Why should I do it?

What is the purpose of the task? What does it accomplish?

When is the task be performed, if in a larger procedure?

Why is the task necessary?

Who performs the task?

Incorrect:

Use this procedure to configure security settings for the XYZ product.

Better:

After product installation, administrators configure security settings that determine who can and cannot use the XYZ product.

Concept topic short descriptions

The concept topic short description answers the following questions:

What is this?

Why do I care about this?

If the concept is unfamiliar, start with a brief definition. Ensure that the short description contains the main point of the topic, why it matters, and to whom.

Incorrect:

This topic covers multicloud data services.

Correct: Multicloud data services provide a consistent interface to multiple cloud platform. For an IT team, multicloud data services provide a consistent management experience and reduce complexity.

Reference topic short descriptions

The reference topic short description answers the following questions:

What are the items?

What do they do?

What are they used for?

Use consistent phrasing across the document set so that your information can be easily integrated into a range of publications.

Short descriptions for Troubleshooting reference topics

Short descriptions for Troubleshooting reference topics describe the symptoms of a problem the customer might encounter and tell them that the topic contains information that can help them resolve the issue.

Short descriptions for API reference topics

API reference topic short descriptions tell the user what the API does, what it is used for, and what it returns.

Task topics

A task topic provides clear instructions to accomplish a specific goal. Good task topics:

Include a brief introduction that provides context for the task, explaining why and when to perform the steps that follow.

Break down each major action into a single step.

Give the information required to achieve the specified result.

Before writing tasks, consider:

What is the goal of the task? What will it accomplish?

Are there prerequisites that users must perform before they can execute this task?

What are the clear, simple steps that enable users to accomplish the goal?

What are the results of performing this task?

Guidelines for writing task topics

Follow these guidelines when writing a task topic:

Use an imperative for task topic titles.

When you write task topic titles for tasks that are performed on various products or operating systems, use the following pattern:

Configure email options (Microsoft Exchange)

Configure email options (IBM Domino)

Install the database (Windows)

Install the database (Linux)

Ensure that each task topic title names the actual task that the user will perform or the result that will be achieved. Anticipate how a typical user might search for information about a certain subject, and write the title to reflect that. For example, the task topic title “Run the Repair Permissions job” is a system-centric title that makes assumptions about the typical user’s knowledge about the “Repair Permissions job”. What the typical user wants to know is how to repair file permissions. A better title would be “Repair file permissions”.

Incorrect: Use the InsightIQ configuration wizard

Correct: Configure InsightIQ settings

Write a short introduction to the task that explains why or when, or why and when, the user will want to carry out this task Some tasks are self-evident; many need introductions.

If you can perform a task in multiple ways, document only the most direct method or the most intuitive method. If you must document two methods, separate them into two topics.

In task steps, use imperative verbs or verb phrases.

Examples:

Click **Save**.

Remove the chassis cover.

Steps are the focus of a task topic. Ensure that other information in the task topic is brief. For example, if prerequisites exceed three items, consider creating a separate requirements topic.

Document only one task in each task topic. For example, in a topic titled “Create a replication policy”, do not include a step that describes how to delete the policy. Instead, create a separate, related task topic that is titled “Delete a replication policy”.

When providing explanatory text about a step, including any description of the results of a step, use the DITA <info> element.

As you write task topics, cross-reference any concept or reference information that users need to successfully complete the task.

Use notes and admonitions sparingly in tasks. Include them only if they are needed for clarity and only if the information applies directly to the task or to specific task steps.

Avoid screenshots. They can waste space, pose translation issues, and are rarely helpful to the user. An illustration or diagram that shows a task flow can be useful for complex tasks.

Do not include unnecessary narrative text in a task topic. Instead, place narrative text in the contextual introduction section that precedes the procedure, or place it in a separate concept topic.

Include only one action per step. However, if you are documenting short steps that are performed in the same place (for example, in one dialog box), you can include multiple actions in one step.

When documenting a sequence of menu-based selections or similarly grouped selections, consolidate all parts of the sequence into one step with the menu cascade DITA tag (do not enter the angle bracket directly).

Example:

Select Protocols > Protocol Settings > NFS.

Topic length for a procedure

In general, include no more than nine main steps in a procedure. If a procedure requires more than nine steps, restructure the procedure or break it into multiple procedures.

Substeps: There is no set limit to the use of substeps. However, if a step requires a significant number of substeps, consider dividing the task into several tasks with a container task that describes the overall process. Similarly, if a significant number of steps require substeps, consider breaking down the task.

Always group steps in a way that is most logical to the typical user. Present a simple flat list of numbered main steps. In some cases, present fewer main steps, one or more of which contain logically grouped substeps. Do not use more than one level of substeps. If a procedure requires such deep nesting, restructure it or divide it into multiple procedures.

Prerequisites and postrequisites

Include prerequisites and postrequisites only if they are necessary for clarity and completeness. Including prerequisites and postrequisites can limit a topic's reusability. Usually, the information can be placed in separate task topics that can then be referenced in the relationship table.

Include in the DITA <steps> element only the steps that are required for the main task. Place any required actions that are outside the scope of the procedure in the <prereq> or <postreq> DITA element.

Concept topics

A concept topic helps the user understand the purpose of a technology, product, or feature. Users typically read a concept once or twice and then do not refer to it again.

Before writing concept topics, consider the following questions:

Who is the audience?

What business need does this technology, product, or feature help fulfill?

Is the type of information you intend to provide readily available elsewhere—on the web, for example?

What problems, if any, are solved by understanding the information in this topic?

Are there any planning activities that the user must perform for the related tasks?

Guidelines for writing concept topics

Follow these guidelines when writing a concept topic:

Use nouns or noun phrases for headings of concept topics.

Avoid starting concept topic titles with the following words:

About…

Using…

Explain the purpose of the technology, product, or feature. Avoid marketing hype; focus on what the technology, product, or feature can do for users to accomplish their goals.

Illustrate the big picture. Use graphics when appropriate.

Reference topics

A reference topic provides quick access to fact-based information that supports the performance of a task. The types of information that reference topics might include are product specifications and parameters, constraints on use or performance, parts lists, comparisons of features, and important detailed information such as the commands in a programming language. Typically, reference topic content supports one or more tasks and contains facts without explanation in a format that users can easily scan, such as tables and lists. Information that normally demands tabular presentation generally belongs in a reference topic.

Guidelines for writing reference topics

Follow these guidelines when writing a reference topic:

Consider the decisions that your reference topic helps users make.

Provide a context so that users understand which tasks are relevant to the reference topic.

To make information easy to find, organize the reference content into lists, tables, and sections.

Arrange the reference information in a logical order. For example, arrange items in alphabetical order or order as presented in the interface.

Use consistent formatting for reference items that contain similar information. For example, if you have several reference topics that contain tables of hardware specifications, use the same formatting and the same introduction to the tables. This improves readability and helps avoid confusion.

Change notes

Source: TWSG

Revised for clarity and accuracy, no substantive changes. Corrected error.

Existing guideline	**New guideline**	**Affected guides (TWSG, APEX SG, DDS, IDS)**
Showed structure that put installation tasks under the overview. And out of context with the guideline preceding it, plus the misspelling of uninstall as unstall. **Topic title phrase** **Here is an example in outline format:** 1. X solution overview (topic type: introductory concept, title phrase type: noun phrase)—typically a topic that introduces a chapter or major section of a chapter a. Installing the X solution (topic type: container/bridge/umbrella concept, title phrase type: gerund)—chapter section title a. Install the X software package (topic type: task, title phrase type: imperative)—task topic grouped with others inside a chapter section b. Install hardware component Z. (topic type: task, title phrase type: imperative) c. Install hardware component Y. (topic type: task, title phrase type: imperative) b. Uninstalling the X solution (topic type: container/bridge concept, title phrase type: imperative) a. Unstall the X software package (topic type: task, title phrase type: imperative) b. Unstall hardware component Z. (topic type: task, title phrase type: imperative) c. Unstall hardware component Y. (topic type: task, title phrase type: imperative)	Replaced with section to show correct hierarchy for examples of a container topic gerund and task topics below it with imperative. Fixed spelling.	TWSG

Writing for accessibility

Introduction

At Dell Technologies, we strive to write content that is accessible and readable for all users. Users may have various limitations that require additional accommodation, including hidden content for screen-reader narration or captions for videos.

Inaccessible content contributes to difficulties in understanding, low customer satisfaction, and even legal issues for Dell Technologies. With 20% of the world's population estimated to have a disability, writing accessible content is not only the right thing to do, but it makes good business sense.

Fortunately, writing for accessibility is straightforward, and some of our authoring tools provide checks to ensure you haven't missed anything. As a content writer, you already try to put yourself in the user's position. Writing for accessibility is about broadening your mindset to include a wider range of user perspectives.

For an overview of accessibility compliance and services at Dell Technologies, see the Dell Technologies Accessibility Center of Excellence in Inside Dell. To learn more about the standards, visit the WCAG 2 Overview | Web Accessibility Initiative (WAI) | W3C published by the World Wide Web Consortium.

Notes

Guidelines here are targeted at non-User Interface (UI) content. Accessibility guidelines for specific UI components are addressed in the relevant topic in the UI component section.

As an author, you control accessibility elements in the source content. How these elements appear in published content may depend on the publishing output process.

DITA writers: This topic provides an overview of the why and what of accessibility, For specific technical details, see the CE&T KB.

Overview of accessibility requirements

Technical accessibility requirements defined by the Web Content Accessibility Guidelines (WCAG) aim to allow the visual and other information to be conveyed in other forms such as large print, Braille, speech, symbols, or simpler language. If you are writing in the Tridion CCMS, you accomplish this with DITA tags. If you are writing in another authoring tool, check your authoring guidelines.

Elements requiring accessibility tags or standards include:

Headings and titles.

Images, including figures, icons, and controls. Accessibility requires describing these in alt text.

Figures also require titles. In DITA, use the figure title tag. In other authoring tools, use the <caption> tag. See Images.

Tables. Tables require titles and, in DITA authoring, descriptions added with the table desc tag. The table desc text ensures that its contents and purpose are understood by all users whether the writer precedes the table with descriptive text or not.

Table columns and in some cases table rows. Table columns require headings. In DITA, this is the <thead> tag. See Tables.

Links. Link text must be human readable, and the link text or surrounding text must convey what the link leads to. Also see Referencing external content for detailed guidelines on link text.

Lists.

Audio and video.

Topics and bookmaps in DITA authoring. These require descriptive text applied with the shortdesc tag. See Short descriptions in Topic-based authoring for writing guideline. Also see the CE&T KB for technical tagging guidelines.

General content

When writing for accessibility, use short, clear sentences to convey what users need to know and do. Refrain from assuming the reader is an expert on the topic. All acronyms, abbreviations, and technical terms need to be defined. Describe input requirements, such as date formats.

Organize the content so users can quickly understand the main points of the content. Consider that the reading level of content should be at the 7th or 8th-grade level.

For non-DITA content: Do not rely on visual formatting to convey meaning to users; screen readers will not convey the intended meaning. If you are writing general content, avoid these commonly used font styles such as:

color, including highlighting

bold (use instead)

italics (use instead)

underline, avoid unless the text is a link, which the screen reader will identify from other tags

strikethrough, ignored by screen readers, which can lead to confusion

Some common symbols are accessible to screen readers and read correctly (such as $ ¢ £ ¥ € © ® & ½ ¾). Still, screen readers cannot read most other symbols correctly. If unsupported symbols are

necessary, provide a text explanation for screen readers' benefit. See topics in Punctuation and Numbers and measurement units for guidelines on some of these characters. An Acrolinx check will catch some of them.

When considering accessibility, using *click* to refer to how a UI element is activated is acceptable and clearly understood even by screen readers or keyboard-only users.

Color contrast in general content

Not applicable to DITA content.

The minimum color contrast ratio (text against the background) is 4.5:1 for normal text and 3:1 for large text. Text 14 point or larger and bold or 18 point or larger is considered large text.

A contrast ratio of at least 3:1 for graphics and user interface components is required.

Headings and titles

Screen readers use the page organization's underlying structures to help users find specific content quickly and efficiently. Use the following guidance for headers and titles:

Every web page or document has a meaningful title or heading level 1.

Use descriptive headings and organize them into a logical sequence.

Users should be able to grasp the meaning of a section based on its heading.

Mark all text that looks and acts like a header as a heading.

Choose heading levels to convey hierarchical order, not for visual styling.

Also see Titles, headings, and headers in Document components.

Images

Screen readers use alt text associated with images to provide context to users. Images should not replace written procedures; they should be supplemental. All images that provide information or function should have appropriately descriptive alt text. Do not repeat the title of the figure or use a link or caption in place of alt text.

The alt text should be as concise and descriptive as possible. Focus on the most essential information: What is happening in the image or graphic? Read the alt text aloud to get a sense of what your user might hear and adjust it accordingly.

> **Examples**:
>
> Average employees spend 26% of their time on one project, 30% of their time on another project, and 44% of their time drinking coffee.
>
> Between 2000 and 2019, the average cups of coffee that an employee consumes at work increased from 1 cup a day to 7 cups a day.

More complex images (such as complex charts or graphs) may require more than a short phrase or sentence. There are several options for providing long descriptions, including using a text link to the long description adjacent to the image or structurally associating the image and its adjacent long description (HTML5).

Consider images with no informational value as decorative. Provide null alt text (alt="") for decorative images, which hides them from the screen reader. Be sure not to add a space between the quotes.

CE&T writers: See the CE&T KB for current details on accessibility for images.

Links

Ensure all link text (inline or standalone) clearly describes the destination of the link. Avoid vague phrases and actions like "click here" or "read more."

Balance making link text concise so that a screen reader can quickly read it while making it long enough that a user will not have difficulty tapping the link on a touch screen.

The link text should inform the user if it leads to a download. Add the file type in parentheses in the link, such as (PDF), or include the word "Download."

For general, non-DITA content: Avoid relying solely on color to communicate the utility of a link. Underlining is a common way to denote linked text (even if the underline only appears on hover). The minimum color contrast difference between links and the surrounding text is 3:1 to ensure users can identify links.

Also see References to external content in Document components.

Lists

Use the following guidance to ensure that lists are readable:

Properly created bulleted lists (<ul> in non-DITA content) inform screen reader users how many items are in the bulleted list.

Properly created numbered lists (<ol> in non-DITA content) inform screen reader users how many items are in the numbered list and read the number for each item.

Bulleted lists are easier to read and process than numbered lists. Use ordered lists for steps in a process or rankings where the numbers provide essential information for the list item.

Also see Lists in Document components for general best practices.

Tables

Create tables with accessibility in mind, so screen readers do not struggle to interpret them. Many tools automatically populate the necessary tags for screen readers, but additional considerations exist when planning the table layout.

Note: In table nomenclature, heading and header tend to be used synonymously. "Heading" is used here, but your authoring tool may refer to these as *headers*.

Best practices for designing accessible tables include:

Include a table title: In DITA, this is the table title tag. In non-DITA writing, <caption> acts as the table title.

Never leave table headings empty. In particular, the top left cell must contain a heading. In DITA, this is the <thead> tag.

If appropriate, include headings for rows as well as columns. The combination may be essential for someone reading the table using assistive technology, like a screen reader or refreshable Braille display. The screen reader will announce the appropriately identified headers as users navigate table cells. The intersection of the labels provides the context for the data to make sense.

Use only one heading row. If one heading row spans multiple columns or the entire table, consider dividing the table into two separate tables or using the header row that spans the table as a table title.

Avoid merging cells so that one cell spans two rows or columns. Some screen readers cannot support spanned cells.

Use proportional sizing instead of absolute sizing. **CE&T note:** XMetal supports proportional sizing.

Avoid footnotes.

Examples of inaccessible and accessible tables

An inaccessible table:

Favorite coffee roast[1] by job title							
Technical Content Developer[2]				Information Architect			
Brand	*Votes*	*Brand*	*Votes*	*Brand*	*Votes*	*Brand*	*Votes*
Dark[3]	21	Light	5	Dark	7	Light	23

[1] – Coffee can be roasted in a variety of manners and achieve a darker or lighter color depending on how it's roasted.
[2] – Technical Content Developer is the standard title for technical writers at Dell.
[3] – Dark roast coffee tends to have less caffeine than light roast coffee. Perhaps Information Architects prefer light roasts because there is more caffeine.

Below, the same information is presented in a table format designed with accessibility in mind. Notice that the complexity of the inaccessible table is broken down into two simpler tables with table titles and heading rows that are easier for screen readers to handle.

Table 4. Favorite coffee roast of content developers

Rank	**Roast**	**Votes**
1	Dark	21
2	Light	5

Table 5. Favorite coffee roast of information architects

Rank	**Roast**	**Votes**
1	Light	23
2	Dark	7

Audio and video

For audio-only content, provide a transcript. For content with audio and visual components, also offer captions. The transcripts and captions should include the spoken word and convey other aural cues in your video, such as music or sound effects. For video transcripts, also describe the important visual content.

Follow these guidelines for video captions:

Caption everything that is said.

Do not correct a speaker's grammatical errors in the captions. Do not paraphrase or substitute incorrect words.

Example:

To fix the problem, consider re-recording the audio and editing the script to correct the subject/verb agreement. If that is not an option, use the grammatically incorrect phrasing used by the speaker.

Use punctuation and capitalization as outlined in this guide.

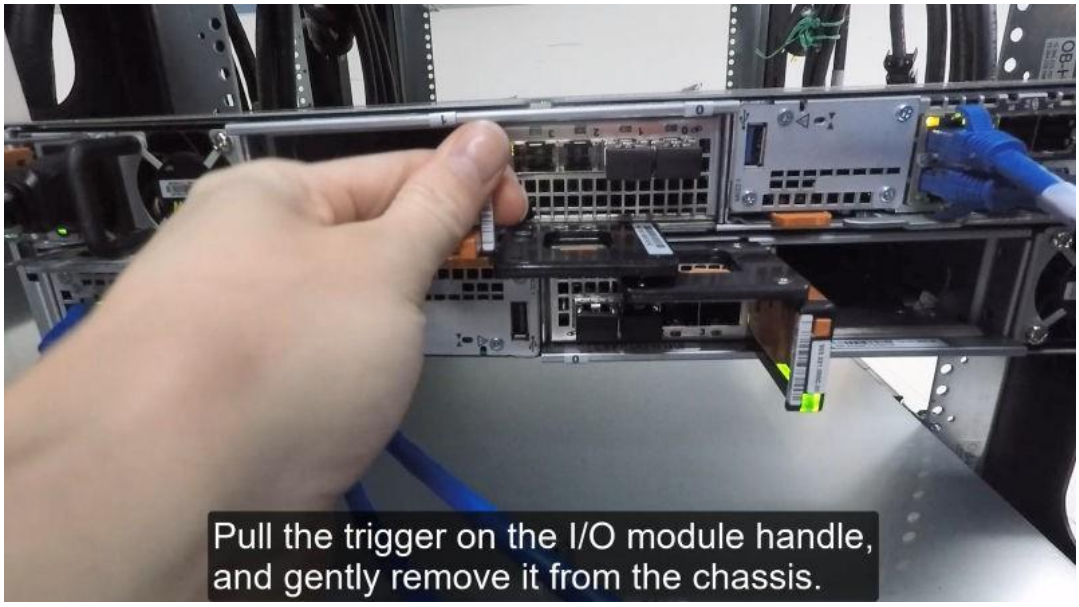
Ensure that captions appear exactly when the audio starts and disappear when the last word in the caption is spoken. Many captioning tools handle this automatically.

Shorten captions so they take up one or two lines. Break captions at natural pauses in speech, typically before conjunctions. Do not separate a modifier from the word it modifies.

Captions should take no more than two lines. If a sentence's caption breaks out onto a third line, split the sentence into two closed captions.

Some captioning tools automatically break captions onto a second line, but if the one you are using does not, avoid having captions longer than 32 characters on a single line.

Example:



Use a non-serif font for closed captioning. Font size is dependent on the resolution of the video, but a font of 24 point or higher is typically acceptable. Some captioning programs recommend a compliant font and font size.

If a speaker spells out a word, capitalize each letter and place an en dash between the letters unless the word is an acronym.

Do not block other text with captioning.

Move captions to the top of the screen if there is important text on the bottom of the screen.

If two people are speaking, and it is not apparent who is talking at the time, add the speaker's name in front of the caption.

Example:

Change notes

Sources:

IDD Style Guide 4.0 (TWSG removed accessibility guidance and just pointed to Dell Accessibility CoE)

APEX SG [Writing for accessibility (sharepoint.com)]

CE&T KB list of checks

Change description	**Guides affected (APEX SG, TWSG, DDS, IDS)**
Topic was missing in TWSG. From this topic in IDD Style Guide 4.0, added new accessibility requirements to align with the CE&T KB and Validator: Titles for figures and tables. In DITA, this is the table or figure *title* tag. Headings for tables. In DITA, this is the *thead* tag. In links, human-readable link text instead of URLs	TWSG
Added accessibility guidelines for non-DITA (direct formatting) authoring.	All

Writing for localization

The following localization guidelines help ensure that global content is easy to understand and as cost-effective as possible to translate.

Guidelines here are general writing guidelines. See Locale format standards for standards for specific elements such as date and time.

How you say it

Follow these guidelines to optimize your writing for localization:

- Use a simple, consistent, and readable style.
- Develop concise, straightforward content. Use short, simple sentences whenever possible. Long sentences, particularly over 20 words, confuse machine translation.
- Be clear and consistent. For your reference, use a glossary to maintain consistency and clarity.
- Avoid stand-alone pronouns, which can create confusion.

Incorrect: The software does not come with a license and it must be purchased separately.

Correct: The software does not come with a license. You must purchase the license separately.

- To reduce confusion, repeat a noun instead of using a pronoun.

Incorrect: Locate the switch on the back of the system bezel and turn it off.

Correct: Locate the switch on the back of the system bezel and turn the switch off.

- Use active voice as much as possible. See Voice, Active and passive.
- Avoid using ellipses. If an ellipsis is part of a user interface, do not include the ellipsis in your documentation. See Ellipses.
- Ensure that your content reads well in English and use Acrolinx to proofread the content to avoid spelling errors, typographical errors, and grammar issues.
- Use simple present tense as much as possible. See Tense.
- Avoid noun clusters (a series of nouns that modify the final noun). Limit noun clusters to three nouns.

What you say

Follow these guidelines for ensuring that your content is cross-culturally appropriate:

Avoid using local or regional information and references. They are less comprehensible to those not living in the locality or region. When content is translated for other regions, local URLs, phone numbers, and addresses all must be replaced or deleted. If you must use local or region-specific content, concentrate the content in one topic or chapter.

If you must use phone numbers, avoid using letters in phone numbers, such as 512-DELL-101. If the letters make a word, they might get translated. See Phone numbers.

Avoid region-specific phrases and words that have different meanings in different cultures.

How much you say

Follow these guidelines to minimize localization costs:

Follow minimalism principles. The more words you write, the more Dell Technologies must pay to translate your content.

Avoid unnecessary change to your content. Consistent use and reuse saves Dell Technologies money.

If content changes are necessary:

A changed paragraph is better than a new paragraph.
A new paragraph or page is better than a new chapter.

- A new chapter is better than a new document.
- Related topics
- Wizards in ISG Design System

Related topics

Banners

Locale format standards

A locale is a set of parameters that defines the user's language, region and any special variant preferences that the user wants to see in their user interface. A locale identifier consists of at least a language code and a country/region code.

In this version of the Unified Style Guide, this topic links to the Confluence page listing official Dell Technologies locale format guidelines:

Locale Format Standards - DTC - TTS DevOps Confluence (dell.com)

In a future version of this guide, the content will be moved and maintained here.

Follow locale format guidelines for localization of these elements, whether in content or in the user interface:

Country code

Language code

Country name

Name

Address

Numbers

Telephone

Currency

Date

Time